

The BEST JOB INTERVIEW Advice Book

Advice from
16 Interviewing
Experts Including
International Recruiters
& Coaches

For Students/Graduates • Workforce
Re-entrants • Career Changers •
Seasoned Professionals

By Devay Campbell, PHR

210
Years of
Interviewing
Experience
in One Book



The BEST
JOB INTERVIEW
Advice
Book

Devay Campbell, PHR

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About the Author



Devay Campbell, PHR is a Career Coach and Human Resources professional with over 10 years' experience coaching individuals, groups and hiring managers in topics related to interviewing, career development, career transitions, conflict resolution and embracing diversity.

She has 8 years of employee management experience and is Professional in Human Resources (PHR) certified. Additional certificates in Behavior-Based Interviewing and Conflict Mediation complements her career development and coaching skills.

Her experience in recruiting, management, and entrepreneurship has given Campbell a unique perspective on interviewing. In addition to leading the hiring process for organizations and her companies, she has also had her share of personal interviews as well. She has mastered the art of selling herself and

standing out as the candidate of choice, which has led to receiving multiple offers on several occasions.

Campbell is the Founder of Career 2 Cents job coaching and advice services. Career 2 Cents provides quality, relevant and timely career advice, and coaching services.

Domestic and International clients alike have solicited Campbell's advice on interviewing, changing careers, navigating workplace conflict and more.

Devay believes that the only thing equal to offering a candidate the job of their dreams is preparing them to attain or navigate their life and career goals.



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Dedications

*In loving memory of my first best friend and brother
David L. Campbell 1976-1997*

This book is dedicated to everyone that has ever entrusted his or her career decisions to me. You have given me the courage and inspiration to write this book.

I would also like to dedicate this book to my daughter, Sequoia Hudson. Everything I have done and will do in the future is to be your example of what a woman of uncompromising integrity, perseverance, and dedication looks like. You are my best work yet!

Alfreda Garner, my mother, thank you for supporting all of my endeavors large or small, and instilling in me that I can do any and everything I put my mind to.

Cecilia Singletary, my confidant, thanks for being a sounding board for all of my wild and crazy ideas! Your constant support, discipline, and impeccable work ethic teach me to be a better person and to strive for excellence in even the smallest of things.

Last but certainly not least; The BEST Job Interview Advice Book is dedicated to all of the contributors of this book. I am grateful for your support and wisdom. I love it when iron sharpens iron! I admire you all and you have inspired me to keep moving forward. I can never repay you for helping me to fulfill one of my dreams. You rock!

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If you want to learn how recruiters read resumes, what mistakes you might be making that prevent you from getting hired, what the best interviewing techniques are and how to negotiate your best ever salary, get Margaret's FREE 5-day video course 'You're HIRED!' at <http://www.interview-coach.co.uk/you-are-hired-video-course/>

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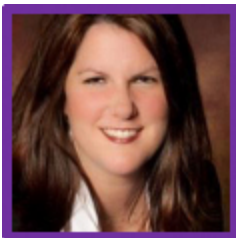
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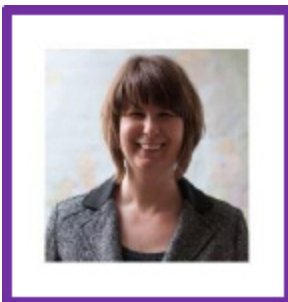
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Introduction

The **BEST Job Interview Advice Book** will give you an up close and personal look at the interview process from the experts' point of view. An expert for the sake of this book is an established professional that has been involved in coaching, interviewing, hiring and selecting candidates for entry to executive level roles.

I have assembled 15 diverse, phenomenal professionals from the USA, India, South Africa, Singapore, and the United Kingdom. Together we have a total of 210 years of interviewing experience!

Most of the information in this book is numbered and is bulleted for quick reference and ease of digestion. There is so much valuable information here; I wanted you to be able to find what you need quickly. I have also provided some pages for you to take notes or capture details that will help you during your interviewing process.

I am sure you want to know why I titled the book **The BEST Job Interview Advice Book**. There are a few reasons why:

First, the contributors and I are passionate about helping job candidates become successful at interviewing. We have provided you with first-hand insight on how to impress managers and recruiters. You see, often have we witnessed the perfect candidate (on paper) blow it in the interview process. We REALLY want to teach you how to align your interview skills to your talents and qualifications.

That brings me to the second reason this book is **The BEST Job Interview Advice Book**.

So many books provide excellent advice on single topics like preparing for an interview, answering interview questions, or negotiating job offers. **The BEST Job Interview Advice Book** provides advice for all of the above and more! I understand that a 360-degree approach is necessary to be successful at interviewing. Writing a book that leaves out one or more facets of the interviewing process is simply not helpful to the job seeker. You need a one-stop interviewing shop!

I want you to understand that what happens before, during and after the interview are equally important. I have aimed to provide you with the tools and knowledge to handle each part of the interview in one book.

Think about it, what benefit is learning how to dress for the interview if you do not know what to say during the interview? What benefit is nailing the interview questions if your personal brand presents you in a less than favorable light? What if you ace the interview but fail to secure the best offer possible?

It would be awesome to get all the information you need in one place, right? Well, you are in luck! This is the place!

In this competitive job market, being qualified is not enough. It takes a good personal brand, networking, business acumen, interview savvy, preparation, and confidence. ALL of these topics are covered in **The BEST Job Interview Advice Book**.

This book was written based on real life scenarios and questions that I have been asked from people preparing for interviews all around the world. Some of the contributors of this book have been paid hundreds of dollars or more for the advice you will be receiving for the nominal price of the book.

I cannot guarantee that you will get every job you interview for; however, I am confident that you will learn something from this book that will improve your interview skills, if applied. I am not ashamed to say that even I learned something from the contributors of the **BEST Job Interview Advice Book**. They really do rock!

Regardless of whether you are looking for your first, next or last job, this book is for you! I am excited to share this information with you. As stated on the cover, new graduates, career changers, workforce re-entrants, and seasoned professionals can benefit from this information.

Interviews are scary and can be life changing. It is ok to admit you need help. Human Resources professionals that interview people for a living often turn to others for help too. Read, practice and apply. If necessary, repeat. Watch your confidence grow and your skills sharpen in the process.

I am so honored you have selected my book to help you on your career journey!

Devay Campbell, PHR
CEO of Career 2 Cents

Receive FREE career tips right to your mailbox! <http://eepurl.com/boZMTb>

Receive a FREE Consultation <http://eepurl.com/bngCez>
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Chapter I

Before the Interview



An interview starts before you are in the market for a job.

A job interview is a two-way, fact-finding form of communication between two or more people that may result in a job, internship or volunteer opportunity. Everything you do leading up to the interview will help or hinder the process. Take the steps you need to be successful now!

Your personal brand

I tell those seeking my interviewing assistance, is that an interview starts before you are in the market for a job. What does this mean? Some of the work and detail leading up to the job interview is the most critical part of the process.

Start improving your personal brand. What is your brand? Think of your brand as your reputation. Your brand is how you want to be or will be perceived by others.

Do not underestimate perception and first impressions. Without someone actually getting to know you, their judgment of you will be based off perception and first impressions. Frequent self-evaluation is great practice for all of us. Ask yourself a few simple (ok, maybe not so simple) questions.

1. What things do I want people to know about me? How do I want to be remembered? Do I want to be known as the party animal, business professional, unfriendly, unreliable, a thought leader, trailblazer, people leader, visionary or subject matter expert?

2. Are there things about me that can be cleaned up or improved? This can include your resume, portfolio, work samples, interview skills, appearance, work ethic, social media presence (or lack thereof), communication skills, education, habits, and associations. Everyone can benefit from self-improvement.

Changing your image should be at the top of the list. Protect your brand. Your professional image, social image, and personal image can keep you from being considered for a job. I hope that you have been a great steward of your brand. If not, that is ok. You can start NOW.

Although some things (like inappropriate pictures on the internet) will never really go away, it is not too late to clean things up. Have you Googled yourself lately? Do you know if there is information on the internet that could be hindering you from getting a job?

While watching Shark Tank (my favorite show), I learned of a business that is geared towards helping to improve the brand of individuals and businesses.

Brandyourself.com is a website with free and paid tools to help individuals and businesses to improve their brand. The site boasts the ability to not only create a positive personal and business brand for subscribers but also bury negative information that may appear on the internet.

The co-founder of Brandyourself.com was missing internship opportunities because a drug dealer shared his name he had. When employers looked him up, they were getting information returned to them about the drug dealer.

After going through that ordeal, he decided to create a company that deals with helping people build a positive online presence.

I decided to use the free tools offered by the site. I was able to register by connecting through LinkedIn. This was simple to sign up. I had 10 results show up under Devay Campbell.

After the results are displayed, you can personally mark the information as “positive”, “negative” or “not me” on the right side of the listings. You can also click the results to see where they lead. Some of the results included my LinkedIn profile, Zoom Info, and White pages. I was able to mark these as positive. Something came up that did not have my name on it so I marked it as “not me” using the options provided.

I did have one alert that was criminal information for a man with the same last name as me. I did not know him and thank goodness, it was not me. I was not able to classify this information so I did not take action on it at that time.

When I continued through the site, there were options for me to upgrade to some of the paid services. I might do that later. The site is simple to use and will give you some insight as to what returns under your name when someone searches the web. The process took 10 minutes. It is well worth it.

You see, getting a job (and interview) is about more than being qualified, applying and waiting. A proactive approach is necessary to be truly successful.

Are you asking for referrals before you need them? Is your voicemail professional? You must work on them before employers start calling you for interviews.

Shhhh...This is between us AND everyone with access to the internet.

Are you watching your actions in private and public? Yes, I did say private actions.

Honestly, are there *private* moments anymore? Just ask the millions of people that have had their so-called private moments on video exposed by cell phone cameras and audio recordings. This has ruined or damaged plenty of well-established careers.

A famous Bounty Hunter was (allegedly) recorded by his son making racist remarks about his son's girlfriend. He had a very successful TV Show before that.

Another well-known actor's 9 or 10 private messages to his girlfriend were exposed for the world to hear. There have also been public figures that have had email accounts hacked and private information, emails and photos leaked to the public.

While I was writing this book, an ESPN reporter was recording (video and audio) belittling an employee of a company that towed her car. She was upset like any of us would be; however, her personal attacks on the employee's appearance and profession led to her suspension from work. I am not sure what will exactly happen because the ordeal is still new. The public is outraged and calling for her dismissal. She has issued a public apology, but the damage done.

Now, I am sure you are saying they are famous and no one cares about my private business. Not true! I am not sure how many video clip I have received for me to laugh, cry or be amazed at non-famous strangers' behavior. Some are downright embarrassing, but we still watch, right? Some of these incidents were recorded and shared involuntarily.

I do not want to hammer this point too much, but I have a true story that I would like to share with you.

About 5 years ago, I attended a rather large job fair to search for job candidates. After a long day of shaking hands, smiling, and reviewing resumes, I encountered a woman that I had seen before. She was approaching me

looking extremely nervous. When she finally arrived at my table, I understood why she was looking concerned. She obviously remembered me and wondered if I remembered her. I did remember her.

About two years prior, I witnessed her in an unpleasant situation. She was having a huge argument with another person (outside) next door to my home. I gave her a five-minute interview just like all of the other attendees (out of courtesy). Even still, I could not forget her behavior that day.

The company I was working for required our client facing talent to be level headed with the ability to diffuse conflict. She certainly was not the one!

I know that people change, but I believe in taking well-calculated risks. Hiring her was not a risk I was willing to take. She was qualified for the job but not suitable. That is another lesson altogether; however, I will say that being suitable goes beyond what is on your resume.

Start networking immediately!

The one thing that will get you past the never-ending sea of resumes is to have insider's information on positions. This can be achieved by networking and being ready to react when an opportunity presents itself.

Join groups and associations with like-minded professionals (especially in the same industry) and follow the companies of your interest. There are also networking events you can attend. Look them up in your city and asked to be added to their mailing or emailing list.

Visit blogs associated with your groups and respond to others' comments and posts. Be an active participant. This way you are already in a position to ask and receive job leads, interviews and invitations to events that may lead to your next opportunity. It is highly unlikely that someone will come to find you in your shell to give you a job.

Even if you are someone introverted, being online can buffer some of the interaction until you are comfortable. Just remember, the conversations may end up offline one day. The chances are also very high that you may have to

interview in person. Networking in person and pitching yourself is excellent practice.



A word from the expert:

Article posted on LinkedIn, February 28, 2015

**Chan Ngee Key| Director of Talent & Coaching| Springboard
Talent| Singapore-Asia
Experience: 5 years**

Networking is Sexy, Not Sleazy!!!

Feb 28, 2015 Article posted on LinkedIn

Recently, I attended a party organized by former colleagues. For me, it is always good to get in touch with old friends no matter how busy I am.

During the chitchat session, I spoke to one of them whom I had just learned was laid off after more than 12 years in the company. When he found out that I was a Career Strategist, he asked me for a quick tip on how to find a good job. As all of us were having a good time and the music was too loud, I couldn't really go in depth to provide him solid advice. I just mentioned that networking is one of the most powerful job search strategy to uncover hidden great jobs.

His immediate response was "Nah, I don't think networking works for me. It is kind of sleazy, unnatural, and quite fake. I can't imagine talking to people or even strangers and asking them for a job. It's like begging and I hate that

feeling. I still think that sending resumes and engaging all the recruiters works best for me." Before I continued to engage with him on this topic, he walked away to join the party with the rest of them.

With this incident, I have decided to share what I think about networking and how useful it is for your job search and to get the job you love.

Networking is the process of using personal contacts to achieve a particular purpose.

Most of us do it as a part of our normal social interactions. When we are looking for a plumber or an electrician to do some work, we invariably ask around for names of people who others have successfully used and can recommend. Within organizations, most people network as a means of finding out what is available and what is going on. This is often called “keeping an ear to the ground” or “office politics” – it is networking nevertheless.

How can networking help your job search?

For most people, networking is the most powerful technique available for getting a new job. Networking can help you research career options and new industries. It provides an effective means of finding out what the culture of an organization is and can provide vital information that can prevent you from making a poor career choice.

Networking enables you to access the hidden job market. This market is where about 80% of people find work. Many potential employers use networking themselves to find suitable employees and never advertise available positions, preferring only to rely on referrals from associates to fill vacancies. In this way, they cut the cost of recruiting.

If you can tap this hidden market, you will considerably improve your chances of quickly finding new opportunities.

Unfortunately, many people concentrate their efforts on advertisements and approaching consultants and agencies who deal with 20% of the known job market. For an advertised job you may well be competing with 100 to 200

applicants and if you make the short list, you will still be competing with two or three others.

With networking, you may well be the only candidate for the position.

Chan Ngee Key



A word from the expert:

**Devay Campbell: Author The BEST Job Interview Advice Book|
Career Coach| Recruiter| North Carolina-USA
Experience 10 years**

When working for local government and healthcare, the organizations I worked for had a Board of Directors. They made decisions in the best interest of the business and kept the mission and vision of the business in the forefront. Everyone on the Board brought a different skill set and perspective to the group.

Everyone should have a personal version of this group. I know that it might sound a little fancy; however, this is a group of as few as two people that you can go to and receive honest feedback and advice. This will be important when you are looking for guidance, practicing your interviewing skills, and help in making tough decisions.

They will also hold you accountable for sticking to your job search, practicing your interviewing skills, making sure you follow up on job leads and keeping you encouraged.

Select this team carefully. They should be people you respect and/or have experience in the work world. They should be a little different from you and

each other to ensure you are getting a well-rounded viewpoint.

Choosing people that will both keep you in good spirits while being firm with you when needed will result in progress.

Devay Campbell



A word from the expert:

Article (excerpts) posted on LinkedIn March 22, 2015

**Devay Campbell: Author The BEST Job Interview Advice Book|
Career Coach| Recruiter| North Carolina-USA
Experience 10 years**

It's spring! New opportunities await. Are your references in order?

Spring has sprung! I know that it does not feel like it to some of us (especially my friends in the Northeast part of the United States) but it really is officially here!

Most people associate spring with the cleaning of their homes, garages, and other physical structures. What about your resume information and reference list? You must revisit these things often to make sure they are properly maintained and free from clutter or useless information, too.

I hope that spring will bring about new opportunities for you, but you must be ready for them when they arise. One way of being ready is to clean up your reference list.

Are you still using references from years ago? When is the last time you actually spoke to the person(s) you have listed as a reference? Do you know if the

contact information that you have for them is still correct?

Call the telephone number you have listed as the preferred contact method. If the number is, still an effective means of communication, then great. This will be a great time to reconnect with them and see if they are still willing to be a reference for you.

Secondly, this is an excellent time to communicate to them that you are in the market for a new job. They will appreciate a heads up and they will be expecting the call. They may have job leads for you as well. If not now, they will have you in mind for upcoming opportunities they may hear about.

You may also use the reconnecting opportunity to go ahead and refresh your reference's memory about the time (dates) that you worked together, how long you have known each other and other key information that may be asked. Let them know the person's name, company, and the telephone number (or at least area code) that the call will come from, if possible.

It is also a good idea to let them know if you are applying for a job that requires a specific skill. It helps if they can speak to that particular skill set versus speaking in general.

Devay Campbell

The Power of LinkedIn:

I can never fully explain the power of LinkedIn. If you are in the business world and looking for a job to expand your network, you should have an active LinkedIn profile. I felt that it would be a disservice to write a book about interviewing and fail

to mention LinkedIn.

I believe we all can agree that the world we live in is shrinking every day - especially with social media. LinkedIn's "About us page" states there are over 300,000,000 registered users on the site.

Over 17 million are in the United States, followed by 9 million in France, and 7 million in Italy. The Netherlands has 5 million registered users followed by Belgium (3 million), and Turkey (2 Million). The areas in the 1 million registered users club are Sweden, Denmark, Ireland, Norway, and Portugal. LinkedIn is available in 24 languages. That is simply amazing to me!

I was blown away but not surprised when a young woman from Dubai asked me for career advice. She connected with me based on an article I wrote (and have included in this book) on LinkedIn. A man from India later contacted me.

As you may have noticed, the contributors from this book are from all over the world. If we can find each other and connect, I am sure you can find someone or a group that can help you achieve your desired results.

Despite some of the random personal postings on LinkedIn, make no mistake; this is not Facebook or a personal social media site. LinkedIn allows you to build relationships for the purpose of networking, and business. Therefore, you should conduct yourself in a business-like manner. After all, your co-workers, and employers (past, current and future) are more than likely on LinkedIn.

Your LinkedIn profile

Create and maintain a LinkedIn profile. A basic profile is free, but it still has lots of value for users. You can start there.

Before you create or update your profile, it will be helpful to browse through other profiles - especially of individuals in your field of interest.

LinkedIn profile photo (yes, you need a photo)

- Select a photo where you are looking into the camera.
- You should be the only person in the photo. Do not crop another person out of the picture. Your positioning is different when you are leaning, hugging or standing close to another person.
- Your attire in your LinkedIn should be professional attire. Sorry ladies, no glamour shots with the boas or cowboy hats. You should be professionally dressed.
- Look pleasant and approachable. Approachable does not mean club, bar approachable. Remember, this is business.
- Update your photo regularly. You may meet people (like recruiters and managers) that will expect to see the person in the photo.
- You may be a selfie pro, but save the selfies for Facebook or Instagram not your LinkedIn profile.

LinkedIn profile content:

- Make sure your employment dates and titles are consistent with your resume or portfolios you will submit to employers. Your LinkedIn profile is like an online resume and should be treated as such.
- Fill out applicable sections completely.
- Make sure you write a strong headline and summary that leads recruiters and hiring managers to want to know more about you.

I read an article recently that said you should not put “unemployed” in

the headline, even if you are. Instead, describe what you bring to the table as a professional (attract your next employer).

- Proofread the content
- Select relevant skills for your profile that relate to your experience. Colleagues and those familiar with your work will endorse you for the skills. These endorsements will improve your credibility and may increase your chances of being approached for job opportunities.
- Get the opinion of someone else (like your personal board) before making the profile “live” and publishing it. You can type your draft in a word document for this purpose.
- Do not include the years you went to school (high school or college) in the profile. This could give others a general idea of your age or cause assumptions. I believe that in a job search you should not give recruiters and managers ammunition for biases.
- View profiles of other in your industry for examples.

Connecting with others on LinkedIn

When connecting on LinkedIn be sure to add a personal note with the connection request. Although LinkedIn is a business site, personal items seem to sneak their way in. With that being said, some people will question whether you have a legit reason for wanting to connect with them. Oblige them by sending them a personalized request.

Beware: There are instances when LinkedIn will automatically send the invite versus allowing you to send a personal note. This may happen when you search by name and have a list of prospects on a page. If you click “connect”, it will send the invite without allowing you to personalize it.

I recently noticed this would also happen when the site posts recommendations for me to connect with in my activity feed. I actually had a woman to contact me via email to see why I was interested in connecting with her. After my explanation and apology for not offering an introduction in my invitation, she accepted my request.

The best way to avoid this is to send the connection request from the person's profile page.

Asking for recommendations

If you are looking for a new job and you are currently employed, go into your privacy controls to limit everyone from seeing all of your updates. Receiving many new recommendations, connecting with recruiters, and following certain companies, may be signs (to your managers and co-workers) that you are searching for a new opportunities.

Other social media outlets

I know that I have spent a lot of time talking about LinkedIn. You should also be aware of your actions on social media sites that are used for personal interactions.

Your associations/friends, things you like, tweet, re-tweet, and your comments (good, bad and ugly) on any social media site will follow you everywhere. As stated at the beginning of the book, your personal brand is very important to your success.

Employers have now added a social media policy to their handbooks. What you do on social media is no longer "personal" and what you do on your "off" time.

Employees have been terminated for speaking ill of the company and their leaders. Engaging in behavior that was not acceptable to the employer, illegal or breaking company policies have also led to consequences for employees. Hitting "like" on a post can have the same ramifications of writing the post yourself. Your "like" is a sign that the post reflects your opinion.

If employers will terminate employees for social media activity, do you think they will hire someone with similar activity? I don't think so.

Make an effort to be more conscientious than ever. I have a personal pledge in this chapter. Sign it if you dare.

Let's make sure you have things in order. If not, you should be working on them.

- My voicemail message is free from music, or other distractions.
- I am not using social media to air my dirty laundry, show that I am a party animal or vent about my boss, family, bad day, break ups and make ups.
- I have developed a personal Board of Directors.
- I have Googled myself, and I am aware of what shows up (good or bad).
- I am not hitting "like" on crude jokes, behavior, photos, or comments.
- I am making meaningful connections online and have deleted connections that engage in inappropriate behavior.
- I am not doing anything in private that I do not want the world to know about.
- I have asked for referrals and recommendations.
- I have a list of references with the correct phone numbers, addresses, titles, and email addresses (professional and personal).
- I have a complete LinkedIn profile.
- I am following companies on LinkedIn (and other sites) that I am interested in working for.
- I have signed up for job alerts at companies that I am interested in working for.
- I have joined new professional groups, started networking and increasing my exposure.



A word from the expert:

**Frann Griffin| Recruiter| Novant Health North Carolina-USA|
Experience 24 years**

I will reflect upon contact essentials:

1. Have an appropriate email address primarily aimed at your job search. An email address such as Hotbaby@yahoo.com is not a good choice.
2. Have an appropriate voice message on your answering machine/voice mail.

You only get one chance to make a good impression, that includes the first key stroke, voice messages and in person by sight.

Frann Griffin

If you are a note taker or a "to-do" list person (like me), I have provided space for you to organize your thoughts and write down your desires.

My Professional and Personal References:

Include Name, Title, Phone Number, Address, Email Address and Relationship

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Groups and associations I would like to join:

[illegible]

I would like to connect with the following people:

I am interested in working for the following companies and why:

The why will be helpful when you are asked, “Why do you want to work for us?” in the job interview.

Additional Notes:

Personal Brand Protection Pledge:

I pledge from this day forward to stop posting, commenting on, or “liking” material that is demeaning to another person or group, racist, sexist, violent, or inappropriate. In addition to that, I also plan to warn my friends, associates, and family members that send me such information to stop immediately.

I will delete unfriend, or disassociate with others that continue to posts or send me inappropriate behavior. I pledge to be more responsible on social media.

I will not participate in anything that does not promote a positive image of me and my brand.

Signed: _____
Date: _____

Get organized: It will be well worth it.

The best thing you can do for yourself is it to get organized. Once you start applying for jobs, it will be difficult to keep track of who, what, when, and where. This is not only important for you to view and decide who you want to interview with, it is also important for you to review when the interviewing process starts.

I do not recommend applying for jobs you really are not interested in (why is later in the book) but get yourself out there. The details of the job may be lost if you wait to write things down. Make sure you somehow keep up with the job posting information. This is your secret weapon to answering interview questions.

The job posting outlines what the employer is looking for (on the surface). When you have an interview scheduled, I recommend studying the job posting. It is helpful to write down the skills you have that correspond to what the employer is asking for. These notations will turn into your talking and selling points during the interview.

However, you choose to keep up with the information is up to you. I will usually cut and paste the job posting and send it to myself in an email.

I learned the hard way that if you try to search for it later, you might find that it is unavailable. One time, the dreaded “this posting is expired and no longer active” message sent me looking for the job posting like it was a million bucks. Even if you have an excellent memory, saving yourself time and set yourself up for success.

One of my pet peeves is calling a candidate and introducing the company and myself and the person on the other end of the phone says, “What job did I apply for again?” My other favorite is, “What does your company do?” You should know this information.

I recommend taking things a step further. Organize a system that will ensure you can quickly glance at the information. Capture information that will help

you remember long after the information has gone cold.

Example 1.

Date:	1/1/2015
Company	XYZ Marketing
Contact Person	Devay Campbell, Recruiter
Position	Customer Service Rep
Relevant Skills	5yrs Inbound Customer Service, Microsoft Office, pleasant personality
Source	Indeed.com
Interest	Close to home, flexible schedules, I believe in products, the company gives back to the community.
Interest Score:	3 out 5
Notes:	This is the company where John is employed. He really likes his job.

One is the lowest and five is the highest score

Help, my phone is still not ringing.

There could be a number of reasons why you may not be receiving calls for interviews.

Unfortunately, times have changed. In the past, a nice resume, extensive experience and great educational background would give you a leg up on the competition.

Today, fancy applicant tracking systems may or may not rank you as one of the top candidates. All of that talk about key words is real, but not necessarily going to get you in front of the hiring manager. Some people even refer to applying online to an application tracking system or a generic career website as the “black hole” because your resume may never see the light of day.

Each recruiter has his or her own way of looking for candidates and working the requisitions (openings) for which they are responsible. A recruiter may look at everyone that applied for a job or use another method to find candidates.

Candidates can be sorted by the date received, alphabetically, location, education or key words depending on what the company’s applicant tracking system will allow. Some Recruiters will use one or more of these queries to get a list of candidates to pre-screen.

If this process sounds like the luck of the draw...that is because it can be. Are you feeling lucky?

What can you do? As stated before, the keywords are an important part of the process. Tailoring your resume to what the hiring manager is looking for is imperative. You have everything you need (including key words) in the job posting. Be sure to highlight the skills and qualifications they are requesting.

Although the job posting is not a formal job description, it does outline what the employer is looking for. The content in your resume should say, “I am the one” without you having to say a word.

Recruiters are not lazy but the easier you make it for them the better. They should be able to look at your resume in seconds (yes, I meant seconds) to determine if you are a fit of the job. Recruiters will not waste time to call you to say, “Hey, it doesn’t seem like you are fit but can you tell me more to convince me you are?” Most of them want it spelled out for them...literally.

Outside of the keywords, one thing you can do is reach out to the recruiter or hiring manager with a brief introduction letter expressing your interest in the position.

Attach your resume to the email or letter. Keep the letter short but be impactful. Talk about your accomplishments using facts, numbers, and percentages.

See the example provided.

Example 2

Introduction Letter example:

Good afternoon Devay Campbell,

I recently applied for the entry level Engineer position you have posted on Monster.com and wanted to introduce myself to you.

I am currently working as an intern with a XYZ company, and I will complete my degree in Industrial Engineering in a few weeks.

After thoroughly reading the job description, I am confident that I can perform the job as described. I enjoying working with quality and production teams to develop efficient processes, save time, and reduce costs.

Recently, I was personally responsible for reducing manufacturing cost by \$25,000 quarterly and reducing production downtime by 29% for XYZ Company. This accomplishment led to me receiving a bonus of \$1000.00 and recognition from the leadership team.

I am eager to speak with you about this opportunity. Call me to schedule an interview at 336-555-1212. I will follow up with you in a week if I have not heard from you.

Thanks in advance for your consideration.

Engineering Candidate

How can you find the hiring manager or recruiter's contact information?

- Call the company and ask.
- Look for connections you may have at the company.
- Research the company's website for a directory.
- See if the hiring manager and recruiter are members of groups to which you belong. If so, you can send them a direct message via the group's page.
- Google: You may find the information and other information about the hiring manager that can be helpful during the interview.

Do you or someone you know, associate with anyone at the companies where you wish to work? Ask them to refer you. This is another way to get in the interviewing door. Sometimes, it will work out for them too if the company has an employee referral program.

Another thing you can do is attach recommendation letters or certification copies with your resume or introduction letter. Some applicant tracking systems will allow additional attachments as well. You do not want to inundate the person with documents but going that extra mile can separate you from the pack.

Another way to get in front of hiring managers while you are looking for a job is to collaborate with a placement agency or headhunter. Recruiters in placement agencies work for a variety of companies and are aware of positions that are not advertised. They will present you directly to the hiring manager. They are your advocates and your public relations partners. They are a free resource for you. The company will pay them when you start an assignment.

A Headhunter will work hard to get you in front of the hiring manager. Of course, their reputation and contracts are on the line so they are only interested in working with professional people that will make them look good. Presenting yourself well to them is just as important as presenting yourself well to an employee of the company.



A word from the expert:

**Margaret Buj| Head of Recruitment at Yieldify| Interview Coach|
London, United Kingdom**

Experience: Recruiter -10 years & Interview Coach 8 years

How to act when a headhunter calls you

Headhunters call when you least expect it and usually when you are at work and it is least convenient to talk. This can sometimes lead to the potential candidate behaving in a way that is unbecoming and rude and they can cut the headhunter off prematurely.

When a headhunter calls, it is because they are working on a role that might be relevant to you but they are also gauging your skills experience and personal character.

Headhunters will have a number of potential candidates to call for a role and will narrow down their list until they get to a shortlist of 4-6 candidates so it is important that you stand out from other potential candidates for positive reasons, not negative ones. If it is not convenient to talk, ask if the headhunter can call you back and give them a specific time when you will be available to take the call and then make sure you are free to take the call at that time.

Always act in a professional manner and you will stand out. Remember that headhunters have strong networks of contacts and could be influential in assisting you with landing your dream job.

Margaret Buj

Another reason your phone may not be ringing is the amount of time you are using to look for a job. Are you seriously looking for a job or is something you are doing on occasion?

Looking for and applying to jobs is a job within itself. I am not suggesting that you should spend every waking hour looking for a job but applying to one or two jobs when the feeling hits you, may not give you what you are looking for in terms of interviews. Quality, not quantity should be your focus; however, you should investigate every lead, and schedule at least a few times a week to apply for opportunities. As a recruiter, I have posted jobs for a maximum of 5 days. If you are applying every once in a while, you could be missing opportunities that were posted and closed before you had a chance to see them.

Does your resume highlight what the employer is looking for? Are you filling out applications completely or listing “see resume” in every section?

Although this is not a book on resumes, I will say that your resume should be tailored to the job. Fill out the entire application, even if you have attached your resume. The application in the company’s system of record is far more important (in some cases) than the resume.

Consider keeping your skills sharp and your resume updated by volunteering, consulting or accepting temporary assignments in your field of interest.

With long gaps of unemployment, it can be harder to prove you are ready to hit the ground running in a new role. Things change so quickly, your skills may become obsolete.

By volunteering, consulting or taking temporary assignments, you will be meeting more people and staying visible. This is another way to build your network and get more interviews.

Check out Elance.com, a site that allows individuals to bid on assignments and work from home. This can be a good place to keep your skills fresh. Some

categories include Writing, Management, Administrative, Graphic Arts, and Finance.

Becoming a consultant will also improve your visibility. This may lead to a full time position. Becoming a thought leader or subject matter expert in your field will set you apart from the competition. LinkedIn is a good place to start blogging. There is an instant audience on LinkedIn and publishing platform is free. Take advantage of it.



A word from the expert:

**Margaret Buj| Head of Recruitment at Yieldify| Interview Coach|
London, United Kingdom**

Experience: Recruiter -10 years & Interview Coach 8 years

How to get more interviews in a competitive job market

To get more interviews, it is very important that you tailor your resume to each job you apply.

It is important that you understand the requirements – e.g. what one company defines as “Account Manager” may have a completely different set of responsibilities in various companies. Make sure you only apply if you fulfill most of the requirements of the role.

Ensure your application is keyword-optimized - your resume must contain keywords that correspond with the description in the job posting, especially if it is industry jargon. Examples of keywords might include specific computer programs or words like ‘e-commerce’ or ‘marketing communications’.

Tailor your Summary/Skills section to match the job description. Make sure you draw the recruiter’s attention to the relevant skills/experience you have by creating a strong Skills section on top of your CV/resume.

Mention recent and relevant achievements that demonstrate the value you bring to an organization and what problems you have solved for your employer. Make sure they are specific and tangible – e.g. if you have saved your company time/money or both – state that.

Margaret Buj

Chapter II

Stop the presses! I have interview action.



How do I know which interviews to accept?

When you are seeking a new opportunity, it is very easy to apply, apply, apply, and apply so more. I understand that you feel that this approach will be most

effective. After all, something will surely come through for you if you blast resumes everywhere and anywhere, right? I agree with you; however, I disagree with your tactic.

With that strategy, you will get something. You just might get a job you really do not want. A job you really do not want starts with an interview you really should not have accepted.

Interviews take time and effort. You have to look your best, drive to the location (wasting gas) and spend hours of your day being on your best behavior to impress others. Make sure the opportunity is one you really want.

I will advise you to take your most frustrating days to relax and regroup. It is ok to take a little break for the sake of sanity. Instead, too many of us say, "FORGET THIS; I am just applying to ANY job." or "I need a job so bad. I will just about do ANYTHING." Really? Think about that for a minute.

Anything?

Do not do that to yourself. Remember the saying, "be careful what you ask for...you just might get it?" The same applies to a job.

Sure, I want you employed and earning the money necessary to take care of yourself and your family (if applicable). I do not want you to apply, interview and accept a job out of desperation only. You deserve the job designed just for you. If it is not your dream job, it should be a launching pad to your dream job. Then and only then, will you come across as passionate about the job, engaged and invested in the success of the company.

As a result, you will you enjoy going to work and will be the best employee. Then, when you depart from the company, you will leave behind a trail of advocates and sponsors. Trust me; you will need them one day.

One side note: Do not apply for many different jobs in an organization. Recruiters (inside of the organization) can see your prior applications. They will wonder if you are serious if you submit applications for different jobs-especially if they are not in your field. Applying to everything also screams

desperation. Make your job search targeted, strategic and precise. Be selective. It may take time, but it will pay off.

How will you know if you should accept the interview? Refer to your information in

Example 1.

Any job you did not rank at least a 3 out of 5 should not be considered. You will need to ask yourself these simple questions as well.

- 1) Is this job something I can really see myself doing?
- 2) Does the job match my skills and interests?
- 3) Do I believe in this company's mission, vision, and products?
- 4) Are the expectations of the job (schedule, travel, basic workload) aligned with where I am in my life?
- 5) Will my family benefit from my working here (pay, work/life balance)?
- 6) Will I be proud of what I am doing at work and the company?

If you feel good about the opportunity after answering these questions, then go for it!

Warm leads: Action is action. It is show time!

I am often asked, "When should I get excited?" The answer is, you should be excited about the opportunity when you apply for a job. After that, anytime you receive a lead, interest or inquiry it is show time!

If someone emails you to gather more information about your background... It's show time! If a friend passes you a contact that they know is looking for someone (now or later) with your skill set...It is show time!

In the first chapter, I said that the interview starts before you are in the market for a job. You have been protecting as well as cleaning up your brand and

waiting on a lead, a foot in the door, and a chance to shine, right? It is your job to turn that a lead from warm to hot.

How can you turn the lead into a hot lead? I am glad you asked.

You are the salesperson and you, and your talents are the products. As a former Insurance Agent, I can you what a good salesperson will do when they receive a lead.

1. They will thank the person that gave them the lead.
2. They might ask the lead provider to contact the lead before them to keep the lead warm. People respond better when they are expecting your call.
3. They will ask questions so that they are prepared and know exactly how to close the deal.
4. They will make an introduction and attempt to meet with the prospect.
5. They prepare for the meeting.
6. They close the deal.
7. They make sure they thank the person that gave them the lead and let them know how things went.

Most hiring managers would rather have a referral from someone they know. Do not be shy, walk through the door that has already been open for you. Remember the “black hole” from earlier in the book? The scenarios above just provided you with a ray of sunshine in the darkness.

Any type of action and interest from a hiring manager is progress and can reap positive benefits. Do not take it for granted.

Types of job interviews and question styles

The best way to prepare for an interview is to ask the recruiter or the person scheduling the interview what to expect. I have never objected to the question from a candidate. In fact, I like it. It shows me the candidate wants to be prepared and is serious about the process. I hope that you have the same

experience. I cannot imagine anyone getting annoyed the question. I advise that you ask.

There is nothing like expecting one interviewer and walking into a room of five interviewers. How is that for throwing you off your A-game?

Do not show up cold to an interview. By the way, it is always a good idea to know how long you should plan to be onsite. Schedule to be there the entire time plus an extra hour. You will not perform well if you feel rushed. Some schedulers will volunteer the information, but some may not. It is good to know beforehand. So ask.

Interview types

Information only —During this type of interview there may or may not be an opening at that time. It is usually a little more conversational and more fact finding. This is a good time for you and the employer to talk about what both of you are looking for.

Ask your questions, too. This is not one sided. Interviews are never one sided- or at least they should not be.

Formal—This type of interview usually means there is an immediate job opening. We will call this “The Big Show” in this book. The Show can take place in person or electronically.

Phone— A phone screening can be as intense as a formal interview; however, it is over the phone. This type of interview can be a little tougher because you cannot see one another.

Make sure you do not have distractions in the background and that you are smiling with your voice. During the phone interview, the recruiter or hiring manager is trying to see if there is a preliminary fit and trying to narrow the candidates down to the individuals that will be invited onsite. It is your job to make it to “The Big Show” and seal the deal.

Virtual—There are numerous programs designed to assist in conducting an interview without sitting in the same room, state or country. I have conducted and been invited to interview virtually. This style offers the personal touch of in person interviews. Treat this is the same as an in-person interview. Dress the part and act the part.

Panel—Some companies will have the candidates visit the site on a few different occasions to see everyone. Sometimes, every decision maker is in one room and interviewing candidates at the same time. Although, this method can be intense, at least you get a chance to impress most of the people that can make the hiring decision at the same time.

The key to the panel interview is making sure you have eye contact with the person who asks the questions and glance around the room at everyone else. You want to make connections with everyone. When you leave, you want to leave more than one advocate for you behind.

The working/hands-on interview—Some interviews have a hands-on component where you would actually perform work similar to which you would perform on a daily basis. One example of this is with Maintenance Technicians. In addition to having a written assessment, the Technician actually has to make repairs. You should be notified in advance if you will have a working interview. Brush up on your skills just in case.

Group—An interview with more than one candidate being interviewed at the same time. I had one group interview when I was 16 years old. This can be very intimidating.

I learned from a colleague that this technique is still popular in the Staffing Industry. In this scenario, you need to shine.

Your competition is right there, vying for the same position right in front of you. It is your job to keep their attention. Try to avoid repeating another candidate's answer to a question. Do not be overbearing or rude. Give others the chance to speak and answer questions but be confident and shine.

Behavior Based/Targeted Selection/S.T.A.R Questions—The interviewer is looking for a specific situation that occurred. Based on the question you are asked, you should tell the interviewer what happened, what action you took and how the situation was resolved.

Example 3: Tell me about a time you went over and above to assist a team member?

Correct answer: While employed with ABC Company, one of my teammates was ill and wanted to leave early (Situation). She had two clients coming in so she was afraid to leave. I volunteered to meet with her last two prospects to explain our products (Action). By me doing so, she was able to meet her goals and leave to take care of herself. I later received recognition in front of the entire team (Result).

Incorrect answer: I would do anything to help my team. I am a team player and try to demonstrate that every day. For instance, I will stay late or give them help when they need it.

When I taking a course to certified to interview in this style, I was warned to stay out of the “woulds” to get the answers I needed. In other words, as a candidate, do not talk about what you would do. Explaining what you did is key.

This interview style is based on the belief that past behaviors will predict future behaviors. Have great examples about things you have done at work. Get in the habit of explaining achievements and your work situations this way. It will help you to organize your thoughts and prepare for other styles of interviewing.

Open-End Questions—Questions that will allow you to elaborate. Be careful not to talk too much. Answer the question fully without rambling and getting off track.

Example 4: Tell me about yourself? Why do you want to work for our company? Why should we hire you?

Closed-End Questions—Require a “yes” or “no” answer. Closed-end questions do not leave room for elaboration.

Example 5: Can you work weekends? Do you have experience with Microsoft Excel?



A word from the expert:

Margaret Buj| Head of Recruitment at Yieldify| Interview Coach|London, United Kingdom

Experience: Recruiter 10 years & Interview Coach 8 years

How to prepare for a competency-based and Skype interviews

In a Competency Based Interview, you will be asked specific questions relating to situations that are likely to arise in the type of job to which you are applying. The questions will start with “Tell about a time ...” or “Describe a situation ...” and then you might be encouraged to elaborate further with questions like “So what were you thinking at that point?” or “What was your decision-making process?”

Skype interviews

More and more companies now are using video/Skype for job interviews. Here are some tips on how to prepare:

1. Make sure your user name and profile picture creates the right impression. You do not want your profile picture to be a holiday photo and your user name should be professional. PartyGirl85 will not cut it.

2. Dress like you would for a normal interview. I have heard of someone who wore sweatpants and an oversize T-shirt for his Skype interview.
3. Avoid an unprofessional or distracting background.
4. Test your Skype connection before your interview. Check that the Internet connection works and that the lighting is flattering.
5. Be aware of background noise. The microphone picks up all noises, so avoid typing or shuffling papers during the interview.
6. Make eye contact. That means looking directly into the camera most of the time, not at the screen or the picture screen of yourself.
7. Sound enthusiastic and energetic, not bored or uncomfortable.
8. Prepare a two-minute pitch about yourself. Really think about how you want to come across and what sets you apart from other candidates.
9. Act as if you are in the interviewer's office. Good posture is important; sit up straight and try not to slouch or fidget.

Margaret Buj

Tough interview questions and scenarios

It is best to practice a series of questions and scenarios. You never know which situation you may find yourself in. The reason I label these as tough interview questions is that people are very rarely ready to answer them.

I also advise my clients to be prepared to answer the following questions:

1. **Tell me about yourself.** Keep the answer business related. There is an example later.
2. **What are your areas of improvements?** Be honest but keep the job in mind when you are preparing your answer. Again, keep your answers business-related.
3. **Where do you shine?** What is your strength? This is your time to brag about yourself. Be confident but not cocky.
4. **Why do you want to work for us?** Be honest and authentic. You should have this answer from your research and a few notes if you followed the advice in Example 1.
5. **Why should we hire you over the other candidates?**

You can use the same information that you mention in your strengths but try to make this answer about what you can do for the company. What can you bring to the role, company, and department? How can you fill the void missing by job vacancy? Talk about your passion for the industry and the company.

6. **Why did you leave your last and previous jobs?**

Do not speak negatively about your last role, company or co-workers. Be honest, too. FYI...terminated is not the same as being laid off.

7. **What are your major accomplishments to date?**

Have you completed a degree or training program? Have you been recognized at work for a project? Did you create a process that saved time or money for your organization?

8. Is there a time you failed, did something you were not proud of or made a mistake?

Tread lightly with this one. Do not over emphasize your weaknesses, and keep it business related. Talk about what you are doing to overcome the weakness. Do not go too extreme with your answer and keep the position in mind.

Always admit to having a weakness because no one is without flaws. You are not doing yourself a favor by coming across as perfect. I wrote an article on LinkedIn going into detail on this topic.

9. Where do you see yourself in five years?

Put some thought into this question. Keep in mind that employers are looking for long-term, committed employees. If your five-year plan involves something that is not related to the company or current position's career path, you may want to rethink your answer.

Even opening a business, embarking on a different career path or quitting to travel the world or something else involving your early exit plan - this is not a good time to mention it.

You want to seem driven and ambitious but avoid seeming like a short-term prospect.

When you are asked about yourself, keep it professional, short and to the point. Make it relevant to the position (if possible). This is not the time to talk about your family, hobbies and other personal matters.

Wrong way to talk about yourself:

My name is Devay Campbell; I am a Career Coach with one child. I really enjoy dancing and going to the movies. I love jewelry, sweets, and teaching people.

Right way to talk about yourself:

I am Devay Campbell, a Career Coach, Recruiter and HR Professional. I have a total of 10 years' experience complemented by my Professional Certification in Human Resources. I am passionate about matching talent to employment opportunities as well as helping people land the job of their dreams.

It is not that your personal information isn't important, or the interviewer isn't interested in you. The interviewers are looking for a brief summary of your professional background. There are subjects that interviewers should steer away from for legal and ethical reasons. These include your family, health, age, sexual orientation, religion, political affiliation, marital status, nationality. You should stay away from these topics as well. Be careful, the "tell me about yourself question" can lead to opening up some of these topics. Do not open up that assortment of problems.

Be prepared for some odd questions, too. They are asked to see how you will handle the pressure of being thrown off guard and/or how you think. What are some of the wildest questions I have heard of? Are you ready?

1. What is the purpose of the fuzz on the tennis ball?

There is no right answer. At least offer an answer!

2. If you had 90 seconds to speak to everyone in the world, what would you say?

Think about this. There are no wrong answers, just make sure it is something intelligent. If you choose to be cheeky or use humor, be careful. Make sure it is interview appropriate.

3. What is your favorite ice cream? You cannot go wrong here. If you do not like ice cream, say so.

Plain Vanilla (although it is yummy) might make you seem...vanilla,

4. If you can be any animal, what would it be?

A snake and/or rat may be bad choices for this one.

5. Tell me something you do not like about yourself?

Do not spill all of the goods. This is just like the weakness question. Be honest but conservative in your answer.

6. If you can take any celebrity to dinner who would it be and why?

Try not to mention anyone that has been in the news for negative, super political, racially charged or other questionable reasons. When you answer why, it could get a little personal and lead to topics that may not be legal or ethical.

If you could have any job in this company, what job would it be?

It is ok to be ambitious and want to move up. Companies like that; however, you need to make sure you tell them that you want the job for which you are currently interviewing! You can indicate that with experience, time and exposure (when you are ready) you moved up. Do not name a totally different position.

**7. What question did you think I was going to ask, but I did not ask?
Alternatively, What question did you hope that I would ask?**

With both of these questions, this is your time to highlight something great about yourself that is relevant to the position.

Example: I was hoping that you would ask me why I wanted to work in the Human Resources field. I really enjoy the balance between advocating for employees and mitigating risk for the employees. I am very passionate about the industry.

I have had numerous personality assessments, taken a three-hour psychological exam, talked to a psychologist and had a polygraph test to get a job. I have learned to expect the unexpected.

Yet, at times, some of the questions you hear will make you pause. Take your time, but have an answer. Giving up without answering will say a lot about you and it will not say good things.

Are you ready for some more nontraditional questions? Check out the next article that was written by expert Erin Kennedy.



A word from the expert

Erin Kennedy Executive Resume Writer|Detroit USA
Experience: 18 years

Article posted on LinkedIn April 27, 2015

Weird interview questions CEOs like to ask.

We are accustomed to any number of conventional interview questions, and everyone has their favorites. But many shrewd CEOs and executives are digging a little deeper, looking beyond what they see in a job candidates' executive profiles, resumes, and cover letters. They are asking some very unusual interview questions designed to reveal more of your personality and ensure you are the perfect fit for their company.

“What would you do in the event of a zombie apocalypse?”

— Ashley Morris, Capriotti Sandwich Shop CEO

+Of course, there is no right or wrong answer here. It's simply a fun question Morris likes to ask to see how a candidate will respond under pressure. This gives him a feel for how effectively they react without prior thought or planning, as well as insight into their moral compass and whether they will fit into the company's culture.

“What's your superpower ... or spirit animal?”

— Ryan Holmes, HootSuite CEO

Holmes feels the response he gets to this question gives him a greater understanding of a candidate's work habits, beyond what's seen on an executive's profile.

“On a scale of one to 10, how weird are you?”

— Tony Hsieh, Zappos CEO

*One of the reasons Hsieh likes to ask this quirky question is to ensure the candidate is a good fit for the casual culture of Zappos. According to Hsieh, whose **company values include fun and a little weirdness**, it's not really important what number you choose, unless it's at the extreme end, such as one or ten. Whereas a one might indicate you are too conservative for his company, a ten, on the other hand, might show a tendency toward being a little too weird for them.*

“Tell me something that's true, that almost nobody agrees with you on.”

— Peter Thiel, PayPal co-founder

Co-founder of PayPal Thiel values those who are not afraid to say what's on their minds. He finds this question, though uncomfortable, helps him see how courageous a candidate can be in discussing something that may be in direct opposition to the interviewer's opinions.

“What was the last costume you wore?”

— David Gilboa, Warby Parker co-CEO

What the candidate remembers wearing isn't a problem. It's more about making sure they fit in with the eyewear retailer's relaxed environment. With core values that include adding “fun and quirkiness” into everything they do, Warby feels that even the most capable candidate would be a mistake to hire if their work style was not a good fit.

“Tell me about your failures.”

– Jenny Ming, president and CEO of Charlotte Russe (former chief executive of Old Navy)

*Resumes and cover letters don't show failures, only successes. Ming feels this question is a good test of how willing the candidate is to take a risk, and being honest enough to acknowledge when things don't go right. The example could come from either personal or business life. What's important is **how the person handled the failure** and how they overcame or moved forward afterward. The clothing store executive says the responses give her insight into how willing the candidate is to admit when something goes wrong.*

So, you might want to start thinking about what your super power or weirdness level is so you are ready for your next interview.

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So, you might want to start thinking about what your super power or weirdness level is so you are ready for your next interview.

Erin Kennedy



A word from the expert:

LinkedIn article posted February 18, 2015.

**Devay Campbell: Author The BEST Job Interviewing Advice Book| Career Coach| Recruiter |North Carolina-USA
Experience 10 years**

You aced the interview. Perfect! Wait... no offer?

Have you walked away thinking that you aced an interview? Then, while you were planning your acceptance speech, you received the dreaded “thanks but no thanks letter” in the mail or the automated generated email from the applicant tracking system.

What? Oh no!

After mentally going over your interview “must do” checklist, you are confident that you did everything perfectly.

Let’s recap. You...

- Wore your best suit and shoes.
- Spent extra time grooming your hair.

- Studied the job description over and over again.
- Highlighted your related experience.
- You presented a portfolio of work samples, accomplishments, and recommendations.
- Sent your “thank you” note after the interview.
- You were nice and personable. You even smiled the entire time.
- Answered every interview question perfectly (even the behavior based questions).

As a matter of fact, everything was perfect! So...what the heck happened?

Believe it not, interviewers are NOT looking for perfection. Don't get me wrong, they want someone they feel can do the job perfectly, mesh with the team perfectly and someone whose beliefs are perfectly aligned with the mission and vision of the company. They are not looking to hire a perfect person.

Employers want authenticity even if it is a little flawed. They want to hire someone that they can connect with and trust.

With that being said, one of the hardest things you may have to answer in the interview is “Tell me your weaknesses.” It is counter intuitive to speak about yourself negatively when you are supposed to be talking about how great you are, right?

Everyone has a weakness or two! Are you humble enough to admit yours? Not admitting your weakness or trying to spin a positive into a weakness is just not acceptable.

Interviewers are so used to that ‘spinning the weakness’ trick. Not admitting to having a weakness is arrogant and will send the wrong message. Plus, it's simply not being realistic.

What message could this send?

It could be a sign that you will hide mistakes, place blame on others or that you really think that you *are* perfect. It may leave the interviewer with other questions about you as an employee like; will you listen to others' ideas? Will you take criticism well? Can you be taught new things? Are you able to identify weakness in others? Are you able to recognize when you or others are in need of help?

Trust me, they will not want to take a chance on you with these questions lingering. Be yourself, be humble, and be honest.

Also, if you do not know the answer to any other question, don't be afraid to say that you don't know. Trying to make something up or to wing it, will make you look worse than admitting that you don't know.

Don't worry.

The "weakness" question is not meant to make you feel bad or to see how much you can deflate your own ego. It is meant to see if you are going to admit to having weaknesses. Some interviewers look to see how and what you are doing to overcome any admitted weaknesses. Either way, you must be ready for the question.

When asked this question, here are a few tips.

- Always, always, always admit to having a weakness.
- Don't get too personal. I know that a weakness is personal but too personal is a no-no. **Example:** Don't talk about the time you had to go to Alcoholics Anonymous or how you are building a better relationship with your parents after years of being estranged. Interviewers don't care about your love of cheesecake, either. Well, maybe that's just my weakness.
- Be prepared to talk about how you have or are working to overcome the weakness.
- When and if you are asked about your strengths, don't name a list of 10 strengths and only one weakness. Now, I would not mention more weaknesses than strengths either. You want the job don't you?

- Be careful which weaknesses you decide to expose. If the job you are applying for is an Accountant role and you mention that you are still trying to grasp the fact that debits must equal credits...I do not think that will go over too well.

Earlier in the post, I mentioned that you must not to try to spin a positive into a weakness. As an interviewer, the weakness that I have heard the most is "I am a workaholic." A close second is "I must learn to delegate." These can be weaknesses. In fact, most leaders and business owners will tell you that they struggle with both of these things. They just seem like "not-so weak" weaknesses.

They are grossly overused and you can do better than that. I have faith in you.

If you must use one of the above weaknesses (although, I hope you think of others), try this instead:

Workaholic: I am really working to have greater work/life balance. Although, I will always give 110% to work, I find that the proper work/life balance keeps me refreshed and makes me a much better employee.

Delegation: I am learning that in order to create a well-rounded, cross-functional team, I must allow everyone on the team to gain exposure to different assignments. What that means is that I must relinquish some of the assignments I really enjoy to other members of my team.

Does that sound better?

Moving on...

I have had my share of interviews so I know how you feel. One of the hardest questions I have had to answer in an interview was, "What is something you do not like about yourself?" I like myself, but I am realistic and can admit my flaws. Of course, I gave an answer. I had to. When I answered, the interviewer asked for another thing that I did not like about myself. Two things that I don't like about myself? Wow! The first one was tough enough.

That was an ingenious way of asking the "weakness" question. If you are reading this (and you know who are), that was a TOUGH question!

Have a backup weakness ready in case you are asked for another one.

Don't just look for the "weakness" question to be asked. Recruiters (including me) are sneaky. We know you have had that question asked the same way for most of your interviewing life. You practice at home, in school and during mock interviews. Yes, we know. Other similar questions include:

- Tell me about a time you failed at something?
- Which class is or was your toughest class?
- Tell me about a time you had to admit to doing something wrong? Whom did you tell? What happened?
- If I asked your current or past supervisor, what area(s) do you have to improve on, what would they say?

Got it?

Are you ready?

Your homework is to think about the way you have answered the question in the past. Did you break one of these rules? Practicing is the key.

Devay Campbell

When the going gets tougher:

Answering questions regarding employment gaps, lack of appropriate experience – when your reason is an incarceration, termination or medical situations.

If you think, the questions above were tough; try answering questions about your gaps in employment, past incarcerations, lack of experience or being termination from a job.

The advice that applies to all of these situations is being very honest. There is nothing more impressive in an interview than being honest. Don't forget to have balance even in your honesty.

Once a candidate told me they lost their job due to absenteeism. This was due to a nasty divorce that caused him to drink a lot. He was absent because he was hung-over most mornings.

I am sure you have heard of T.M.I. (too much information). Sometimes, less is more. Use your best judgment with what you choose to share.

Gaps in employment can best be explained with a simple explanation. Don't make excuses!

One of the toughest things to explain (I would think) is being incarcerated or being terminated.

Gaps in employment due to incarcerations.

I spoke to 132 ex-offenders at the in Washington DC, and I will give you the same advice that I gave them if you are in their shoes. Pay close attention to the wording on applications.

If asked if you have had a conviction in the last seven years and it has been eight years, your answer is no. If they ask about convictions in six years, the answer is yes. If asked have you EVER been convicted of a crime, the answer will always be yes.

If you had a charge expunged, you may not have to disclose conviction that at all. Check the laws in your state regarding expunged records. I am not an attorney or in a position to give legal advice.

Watch out for whether the application or interviewers are speaking of felonies, misdemeanors or arrests when answering questions about your record.

Most companies ask about convictions only. Do not disclose arresting information unless you were convicted. Arrest information can be used to

prejudice the interviewer against you. This could leave a negative impression and could sway them towards other applicants.

In North Carolina (check your state), failing to pay child support and getting arrested due to that failure, is a civil charge - not a felony or misdemeanor. In addition, a Driving While Impaired (DWI) or Driving Under the Influence (DUI) is a misdemeanor. Even though it also happened in the car, it is not considered the same offense as other traffic offenses. It is a crime!

Other traffic violations may not be listed on your record as misdemeanors. In fact, most applications will use the wording “other than traffic violations” or “including traffic violations.” If you have a job that requires you to drive, you may be questioned about your driving record.

If you are dishonest about violations, the consequences could cost you the opportunity even if the conviction or answering “yes” would not have.

Incarceration explanation and gaps in employment:

Try answering the questions similar to this: I did something that caused me to be incarcerated. I have learned from my mistake and I am eager to gain employment and move on.

Whether you have been incarcerated, or have any kind of offense that you must explain, do not EVER make statements like:

- All I did was _____.
- It really was not that serious.
- They (meaning anyone within the legal system) went too far. They could have let me off/slide.
- It was not my fault.
- I really did not do it but they thought I did.

You really want to convey that you made a mistake and you learned from it. The statements above indicate that you are placing blame elsewhere or you do

not think what you did was wrong.

If you do not think the action was wrong, you may run the chance of doing it again (at least that will be the thought of the interviewer).

Even if the above statements are true, if you were convicted of a crime (or took a plea) there is no need to explain too much in the interview. What is on the background report will be taken at face value.

Instead, say things like:

- I was younger when that happened. I have matured.
- That will not happen again.
- I was with the wrong type of crowd and I am no longer associated with people like that.
- I learned my lesson.
- I have not done anything like that since then.
- I am ready to move on and put my past behind me.

Explaining being terminated from employment

Try saying something similar to this: Unfortunately, my relationship with XYZ Company ended involuntarily for me. I take full responsibility for what happened. It was a great learning experience and I am looking forward to moving on from it.

Saying things like the following will show that you are still bitter, you did not learn any from the incident, and that you are not accepting accountability.

- That company is all messed up.
- Management did me wrong.
- I am suing them for getting rid of me.
- They had it in for me anyway.

- I do not know why I was the only person they fired.
- They did not even tell me why they fired me.
- All I did was_____.
- All I said was_____.
- Plenty of people did what I did and they are still there.
- They discriminated against me because they do not like_____.
- Do not lie and say “I was laid off” if you were in fact terminated.

Even if you honestly feel that you were treated unfairly, do not bring any baggage into the interview.

Be honest, take full responsibility, let the interviewer know you have learned and are ready to move on.

Health related gaps in employment

Questions related to your health should be avoided in an interview. You should avoid going into too much detail surrounding the facts but you must explain the gap in employment. In this case, you should simply say, “I was out of work for medical reasons”.

You are not obligated to tell the interviewer what the illness was, how it was treated or if you are currently taking medication.

They may ask if you can perform the duties of the job. Sometimes that question is followed by “with or without” reasonable accommodations.

If you know that you are unable to perform the task of the job, do not say “yes” for the sake of getting a job. It is just not worth it. Being honest with yourself is just as important as being honest with the interviewer.

Lacking experience

There are times when we are “almost qualified” or lack all of the qualifications of the job. The person reviewing the information obviously decided you were

worth looking at a second time. It is up to you to make that second look at you worth it.

Talk about the things that you have done in school, work or during volunteer assignments that can transfer over to the current role. If you made it to the interview, they are interested in what you have to say. Most employers believe you can teach skills so they hire for personality and cultural fit. I happen to agree.

In addition to talking about your skills that are transferable, you have to show you can fit well with the team. Be likable and be sure to talk about your abilities: Flexibility, Reliability and Adaptability.

SWOT: self-awareness

Do you know if you have things you say or do when you are nervous? Most of us do something whether we know it or not. There are also interview types and people find most comfortable. Most of us are most comfortable with interviews where we can just talk and be ourselves.

Practice helps you to identify your interview and nervous quirks and make improvements. Interviewers expect a little nervousness. You can still be confident and be a great interviewer even if you are nervous. It is my job to prepare them. Being prepared naturally increases your confidence level. Practice to improve your weaknesses; do not just concentrate on what you do well.

A huge part of knowing yourself is to take a long, hard look inward. Solicit some help if you need to.

Most businesses will do a SWOT analysis. SWOT is an acronym for strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats. You can do a SWOT analysis on yourself. You are the CEO of the business of YOU. Career changers, students and individuals trying to figure out their next move are excellent candidates for a SWOT analysis.

Keep in mind that strengths and weaknesses are personal or internal. They are about you. Opportunities and threats come from external forces.

Let's start!

What are my strengths? What do I do well? What are my selling points?

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

What areas do I need to develop?

Where are my improvements needed?

What is holding me back?

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

What opportunities exist that will help me to do better or elevate myself?
What can I leverage to help me?

What can I leverage to help me?

[illegible]

What threats are keeping me from elevating and progressing or doing better?

[illegible]

Additional Notes:



A word from the expert:

**Paula Beecher| Director of Career Services-Clemson University|
South Carolina-USA
Experience: 18 years**

My biggest advice for students who come and see me to prepare for interviews is to do a self-assessment prior to the interview. If a student has not identified in their own mind what makes them stand apart and what their strengths and weaknesses are, they most likely will not be able to convey that to an interviewer.

Most interviewers are looking for confidence in ability as well as an acknowledgement of one's knowledge, skills, and experiences. Therefore, candidates really getting to know themselves and practicing putting those qualities into sound bites and using powerful descriptive words really stand out in the interview.

As an entry-level candidate, most students' experiences will mirror other like candidates. The candidate that is able to talk about their experiences and make those experiences applicable (using transferable skill examples) to the job they are applying for will most likely be the candidate chosen.

Paula Beecher



A word from the expert:

**Kimberly Lachelle| Founder and Chief Mom at Speed Beautiful|
Georgia-USA
Experience: 8 years**

Bring something to the table if you lack experience or are seeking an internship,

Often times when applying for an internship or entry-level position, one will not have the experience in the field in which they are applying. In your mind you think, "If I could just get my foot in the door, to this or that company, it will provide me with the income and opportunity I need."

You need something, but what skill set do you possess that can benefit the employer? While you may not have operated in the role, surely you have valuable interpersonal skills that would make you a great candidate. Think about it. Answer the question, and make sure you look for opportunities during the interview to communicate it to your interviewers.

Make sure to read their core values, vision, and mission and communicate how you mirror those values in your own life currently, and how you would continue doing so with the company once hired.

Have a portfolio

Others that are applying for the job may not have any more experience than you may. So how do you stand out? Combine your best work samples into a professionally assembled portfolio to share during the interview. This will also help you level the playing field with applicants that may already have experience. Have someone look over your samples and wherever possible, bring copies that you can leave with each interviewer.

Bring Letters of Recommendations (*current & past teachers and employers*)

Lack of work experience generally is not an obstacle to landing an internship or entry-level position, your personality is. Bring letters from your teacher or managers, past and present, which highlight how great you are with customers and co-workers. These letters should include mention of any awards, or efforts that were above and beyond what was expected of you. At a minimum, the letters should help the employer envision you as a pleasant employee who is more than worth the time and money it will take to teach you the job for which you are applying. Bring copies that you can leave with each interviewer.

Kimberly Lachelle

[illegible]

Chapter III

The Big Show: Time to Interview



Prepare, prepare and prepare some more!

This is what you have worked for, waited for and prepared for.

Remember the five P's: Proper preparation prevents poor performance. Well, there were actually six P's but I decided to leave out a word. This is a G-rated

book. I hope that you understood my point without the other P-word.

You may think that people that seem to get job offers are just lucky. Luck has little or nothing to do with it. They are prepared. Even if you do not see the preparation front and center, it still happens. Maybe they built a network, went back to school or excelled in their current job to deserve a promotion. I guarantee you that somehow they did some preparation.

Even if they landed a job because they were the in-laws of the CEO, they had to marry the right person and that certainly took planning and preparation. You get the point.

Being prepared will automatically give you a boost in confidence, and confidence is attractive to an employer.

Let's recap to make sure you are ready for the interview before we receive advice from the experts.

- You have protected and cleaned up your brand.
- You have studied the position and can convey how your skills relate to it.
- You have identified the position as one want.
- You have researched the company and it is a good match.
- You have practiced different interviewing styles and popular questions with a professional (if possible) or a trusted friend.



A word from the expert:

**Devay Campbell: Author The BEST Job Interview Advice Book
Career Coach| Recruiter |North Carolina-USA
Experience 10 years**

Practice minimizing things you do when you are nervous. Do you laugh, blink, divert your eyes, say “um” or play with your hands? I believe everyone has nervous behaviors. Be aware of what your something is. Once you know what it is, practice minimizing it.

Mock interviews really can help. Solicit the help of a professional if you can or recruit an honest family member or friend to help you. Practice looking in the mirror if the “something” you do is physical. If it is something you do is audible like laugh or say “um” then record yourself. You can download a voice recorder on a smart phone.

Give your interviewing coach/friend a dollar every time you display that nervous behavior and practice until you can walk away without paying anything or a lot less than when you started.

Devay Campbell



A word from the expert:

**Margaret Harris| Sr. Director of Human Resources| Hospice
Palliative Care of Charlotte |North Carolina-USA
Experience 15 years**

Know the company you are interviewing with. There is nothing worse than asking an applicant what they know about the company and have them say "not a lot". Applicants should make every effort to research the company and if they know whom they will be interviewing with, they should know something about that person as well.

There is this thing called the "internet" and "Google" it is actually now a real word and a verb! There is no excuse for an applicant to come to an interview and not know anything about the company. Not knowing is a red flag and an indicator to the employer that the applicant is not being "intentional" about the process. They are just looking for a job, not a career.

Margaret Harris



A word from the expert:

Apeksha Ahluwalia| Manager, Human Resources| Johnson & Johnson| Mumbai, India
Experience: 5 years

- Arrive at least 20 minutes early.
- Take a bathroom (bio) break before the interview starts.
- Know why you have chosen to apply for this specific job.
- Research the people whom you will be interviewing with and, if possible, send them a LinkedIn request.
- Give a pep talk to yourself!

Apeksha Ahluwalia



A word from the expert:

Alisa Quick, PHR, MPA| Director Human Resources & Public Relations| Housing Authority of the City of Winston-Salem|North Carolina, USA

Experience: 15 years

Know your numbers. Make sure you have an idea of an appropriate competitive salary to request prior to arriving. Ensure the interviewer/recruiter that your compensation is negotiable. However, keep in mind what you are truly willing to accept in order to make a transition to a new company (bottom line). In addition to monetary compensation, always consider other forms of compensation and benefits.

Benefits may include (but are not limited to) a flexible work schedule, telecommuting, matching corporate 401k contributions or retirement plans, corporate vehicle use or reimbursement for business use of your personal vehicle. Opportunities for professional development and continuing education are always a plus.

Alisa Quick



A word from the expert:

**Candace Aldridge| Recruiter| Certified Personnel Coach|
Hanesbrand Inc.| North Carolina-USA
Experience: 13 years Recruiter, Certified Personal Coach 10 years**

Remember that interviewing is a two way street. Not only are you being interviewed but, you are interviewing the organization as well. The job needs to be a fit for you just as much as you need to be a fit for the job. Do your research before the interview and ask many questions, not only about the job responsibilities but also about the culture and team.

Print out the home page of the company's website and take it with you to your interview where you have jotted down some questions and have some facts about the company to talk about.

Your job going into an interview is to determine if this company is a place where you want to spend at least 40 hours per week of your life.

Candace Aldridge

To dress or not to dress - that is the question

I have hired people in a variety of entry-level roles. In these roles, neither the hiring manager nor I expected candidates to come dressed in suits and formal interview attire. I have even overlooked jeans. Will I advise a candidate to wear jeans? Absolutely not!

Instead of jeans, wearing slacks and a polo or button up shirt with shoes (that are not sneakers) is acceptable. Ladies, a nice shirt with slacks pants or skirt will work, too.

I also recognize that interviewing with a retailer that sells apparel may mean that wearing their style of clothing will give you a leg up on the competition. They want someone that will fit in. You should check on the interview attire so that you will be ready.

For anyone else, I recommend a suit. Ladies, a pants suit is ok with me. I know people that will advise you to wear skirts or dresses. I have landed the majority of my opportunities in a pants suit. The suit color for male or females should be solid colors including navy blue, black, and greys. Men, wear a button up shirt and a tie. Your tie can certainly have color but do not get too extreme. Avoid colors that are too loud and distracting.

Keep jewelry to a minimum and avoid big, bulky, flashy jewelry. Small stud style earrings are best.

Being neat, clean and well groomed is not negotiable. It is one of my rules to have my last drink and meal before I am dressed for an interview. If you smoke, I would also add smoking to that list.

By doing so, you can ensure that you are not in a position where you could drop something on your interview clothing before the interview. Smoking (even with the window down) will lead to an unfavorable smell on your breath and clothes. It could also lead to a stain or hole in your clothing.

Remember the “less is more” rule. For interview purposes, this applies to talking, jewelry, make up, and perfume/cologne. “Less is more” does not apply to the actual amount of clothes. Show as little skin as possible.

I would also advise you to try on your interview outfit a few days earlier. You should check to make sure it fits well and that all the buttons and zippers are intact. If you need to have it pressed or dry cleaned, you want to allow enough time for this to happen. If things do not go as planned, allowing a few days in between will give you time to purchase or borrow something else.

Waiting until the day of the interview (or the night before) can leave you disappointed.

You want to look your best for an interview, but this may not be the time to try new looks such as a new haircut/style, new glasses, new makeup selection, or anything that will affect your appearance. If these things are not pleasing to you, it will lead to you feeling uncomfortable and insecure in the interview. Discomfort will come across in your body language, posture and answers.

Remember that being your best in an interview is all about being confident, strong and prepared. Anything that reduces any of these adjectives may cost you the job.



A word from the experts:

**Margaret Harris| Sr. Director of Human Resources| Hospice
Palliative Care of Charlotte| North Carolina-USA
Experience 15 years**

All applicants should know that it is not "old fashioned" to come to an interview dressed appropriately. No matter what you hear about how much standards have been relaxed in the workplace, the people in charge still want to see people who "look the part." After all, there is very little that an employer can rely on besides that first impression.

There is no guarantee that the person will be good at the job (not even based on their resume or recommendations). The first meeting and how a candidate presents is an indicator of judgment, desire for the job, and business acumen.

Margaret Harris



A word from the expert:

**Karen McConnell Jones |CEO & President of Class Act
Productions LLC| Maryland-USA
Experience: 20 years**

As an image consultant, I believe that the way you present yourself is very important. Jeans are never acceptable. I also believe that khakis are too casual for an interview. Ladies be aware of how short your dresses and skirts are. Sleeveless shirts are never appropriate. Some heel lengths (stilettos) can be inappropriate for an interview. Be mindful of your heel height.

I once conducted an interview where the candidate interviewed with their Bluetooth device still attached to their ear. Even if your phone is on silent, remove the device from your ear.

Karen McConnell-Jones



A word from the expert:

**Kimberly Lachelle| Founder and Chief Mom at Speed Beautiful|
Georgia-USA
Experience: 8 years**

Dress for the job

Dress professionally. This instruction may be a bit subjective, but think as though you are selling a house. Would you keep your favorite Bob Marley tie-die painting up over the mantel during an open house? No. You de-personalize, de-clutter and make sure everything freshen up. It is no different with your personal appearance. If your hair color or style is distracting or super "creative", pull it back and away from your face so that the interviewer is focused is on you.

Kimberly Lachelle

Ready, get set...

Yes, you guessed you must prepare some more. Find out exactly where you are going and all of the arrival details. The recruiter can be helpful. Do not assume you will know where to park and where to go when you arrive. I interviewed for a place that had multiple entrances and parking lots. I also once worked at building that had very limited visitor's parking spots and the majority of interviewees had to park on the street at a paid parking meter. Quarters, anyone?

I suggest asking the person that schedules the interview to send you an email with the address and any relevant information. They will usually do this anyway. Ask about parking and entrances. It is a good idea to visit the place before the day the interview is scheduled. If possible, travel the same time you would travel to the interview. This will give you a realistic view of the traffic at that time.

If you using public transportation, a dry run will give you an idea of how long it really takes to get from your home to your destination.

Go!

Arrive early enough to check in with 15-20 minutes to spare. Do not be too early. Show respect for the interviewer's time. The interviewer(s) may feel rushed to start the interview if they feel you are waiting too long. If you arrive too early, sit in the car a while, review the job posting and your resume to be better prepared.

It does so much for your confidence when you are prepared, unrushed and poised.

Only a few people can make the decision to hire you, however, anyone in the company can keep you from getting the job. What does this mean? You need to make sure you smile, speak and be kind to everyone you encounter. Being rude, snappy, impatient and indifferent will surely get back to the hiring

manager. The “fit” of the candidate is what is most important at this point. Everyone invited to interview will be just as qualified as you will. In addition to being pleasant, avoid these things.

1. Do not arrive with your music playing too loud. It is a good practice to turn the radio off or completely down when you are a few blocks from your destination. Playing loud music is not only rude; the type of music can cause people to prejudge you. I will not run down the list of stereotypes that follow lovers of heavy metal, hip-hop, reggae, gospel music and other genres, but I will say that you must be aware that they exist.
2. If you have time, visit the restroom to avoid having to go during the interview. If you do not have to go, this will be a great opportunity to look over yourself to make sure you are neat and make adjustments if necessary.
3. Do not smoke on the premises. Remember, this can leave the smell in your clothes and some locations are moving to or have already adopted being smoke and tobacco-free (including vapor cigarettes). The last thing you want to do is break a rule.
4. Do not talk on your cell phone (or text) while you are in the building. Most of us are unaware of how loud we are talking and who is around us. Depending on the nature of the call, it can throw off your A-game and have you a little distracted in the interview. You may also forget to turn the phone off or silence it. I recommend leaving the phone in the car.
5. Keep your energy level high.
6. While in the interview, avoid the urge to check the time repeatedly. You should have asked how long the interview would last when you confirmed the interview and allotted the appropriate time. The interviewers are busy and may keep up with the time for you.
7. There are times you may have to discuss negative things, however, your attitude and tone should be positive. If you are asked what you did not like about your last job; do not get caught up in the opportunity to bad mouth the boss and everyone else.

8. Do not ever use profanity - even in a joking way.
9. Bring something to take notes. You will be getting valuable information that will help you with the thank you letter and the information collected could be helpful in your decision to move forward with additional interviews. Do not rely on your memory! You are sure to miss something.
10. It is great if you know someone at the company or if you have a common acquaintance with the interviewer. Do not rely on this connection to get you the job (even if they referred you). In the interview, stand on your own merits and show them that you are capable of meeting their needs. Be careful not to name drop too much.
11. Do not talk about what you want and need too much. Be sure to address the company and department's needs too.
12. If you are applying to a position within your current company, take the interview seriously. Even if you know everyone in the room, do not rest on the fact that they know you and assume you do not need to give details of your skills and accomplishments. Speak to them as if they were strangers and you were an external applicant. More than likely you will be competing with any internal and external applicants that will come to win them over. You should do the same thing.
13. If you are an internal applicant, do not be afraid to talk about things you have done inside and outside of the organization to make you qualified for the position. Have you taken a class? Have you volunteered on the side? If these things are relevant to the position, talk about them.
14. Do not show your hand too early. Say what is necessary about other opportunities you may be considering without revealing too much. It is common that interviewer(s) want to gauge where you are in your job search with other companies.

Be honest about the fact that you have or have not had other interviews but do not go into too many details. If they feel you are close to getting a job offer, it could cause them to be scared to invest too much time in you.

However, if they are interested, they may move forward faster. When

people ask me to rank them in comparison to other candidates or ask how many people I have interviewed for a certain job, I do not reveal too much. I may say something like “we have had a lot of interest in the position”. This is answering the question without revealing too much. I do not want to scare them into thinking they do not have a chance. I also do not want to give them false hope. You should take that same approach.

15. Memorize the information on your resume. Do not look at it constantly and read the information from it. This will cause serious doubt of the validity of the information and make you seem ill prepared.

Things you should NEVER say in an interview.

When doing research for this book, I asked a variety of people what they would want in a book about job interviews. The number one thing that each one of them said is “What not to say”. Throughout the book, the contributors and I have answered this question relating to various scenarios, however, the topic needs a separate section.

These are things (in my opinion) that you should avoid saying in an interview.

1. Tell me about your company. You should know this already!
2. I did not like my last boss (or any of them for that matter). Even if you have the worse boss in the world, the interviewer may think the problem is you. He/she may also wonder what you will say about them if you are hired. Be positive. Check your negativity at the door.
3. I did not get along with or like my co-workers. See #2
4. I will do any job you have. This sounds desperate. Remember, your job search is specific and targeted.
5. I desperately need this job. Do not act desperate and do not say that you are.

6. I told you about that in my resume/application. They know this. You should be able to convey your skills and background on the spot of time. Do not expect that your resume/application will do the talking for you.

7. You know what I am saying? Actually, they may not know what you are saying if you are using slang throughout the interview. Speak intelligently.

8. Calling the interviewer by a nickname that you made up. For instance, the interviewer He introduces himself as Bobby Knight and you call him BK, Bob or Bobster or B-nice.

9. Using jargon and acronyms of which the interviewer may not be familiar. If you are not sure, err on the side of caution.

10. Nope!

11. Yep!

12. About that... When I hear that, I prepare for something that may be less than true.

13. Do not be overly apologetic. "Saying I am sorry I am a little nervous", "I am sorry I dropped my pen", "I am sorry I don't have that skill",,,This is a sign of passiveness. You want to be assertive and confident.

14. Am I doing a good job with the questions? This seems insecure.

15. That was not my fault. Be accountable.

16. It was_____fault. Do not place blame.

17. Am I one of your top choices for the job? This may show that you are insecure. Do you really think they will say yes or no?

18. How much is this job paying? You should research this and be prepared when the employer inquires about your salary expectations. If you give your expectations, it is ok to ask, "Is the salary within the range of my expectations."

19. You should hire me; I will not be on the market long or you will be missing out if you do not hire me. Do not be cocky. Be confident but have balance.

20. Nothing. You have to communicate with the interviewer. You not only need well thought out answers, you need well-thought out questions.



A word from the expert:

**Candace Aldridge| Recruiter| Certified Personnel Coach|
Hanesbrand Inc.| North Carolina-USA
Experience: 13 years Recruiter, Certified Personal Coach 10 years**

To calm your nerves before an interview, take a deep breath, put a smile on your face, and walk into your interview with confidence and enthusiasm.

Candace Aldridge



A word from the expert:

**Devay Campbell: Author The BEST Job Interview Advice Book|
Career Coach| Recruiter |North Carolina-USA
Experience 10 years**

The best thing you can have in an interview is balance. It is nice to be professional but do not be too stiff. Show your personality but do not get too personal. Be confident but not arrogant. Be humble and modest but be able to toot your horn.

The best candidates have the skill set and will fit well into the team. You can teach skills, but personality is another story. All personality without knowledge and skill can be tricky, too. A nice balance of both is the key.

Devay Campbell



A word from the expert:

**Margaret Harris| Sr. Director of Human Resources| Hospice
Palliative Care of Charlotte |North Carolina-USA
Experience 15 years**

Applicants should not make the mistake of thinking that the "digital age" trumps business etiquette or appropriate behavior.

An applicant should **NEVER** answer their cell phone in an interview. In fact, the applicant's phone should be turned off. Answering the phone in an interview is disrespectful and again indicates poor judgment on the applicant's part. Finally, (don't laugh because I actually had this happen), an applicant should **NEVER, EVER**, read or answer a text while in an interview!

Doing either of these things will get an applicant eliminated. In fact, the interview will probably be cut very short.

Margaret Harris



A word from the expert:

**George Pantazakos | Sr. Recruiter | Herbalife Manufacturing |
North Carolina-USA
Experience: 15 years**

Once you get to the hiring manager interview, I like to tell my candidates to flip the situation around. Often a manager, especially a newer manager, will sit down and before asking any job-related questions, they will ask if the candidate has any questions. This is your chance to take control and get the inside scoop. I tell candidates to jump on this and ask one simple question that will allow them to tailor their answers.

Manager: Do you have any question before we get started?

Future employee: Yes, this position has been described to me as (Fill in the blank).... How would you describe the position?

I know it does not sound like much BUT many managers are happy to talk about the job and will go into detail regarding expectations, issues, and say exactly what they want to hear.

This gives the interviewee a chance to respond to what the manager wants and give very specific examples as to how their experience meets what the manager is looking for.

George Pantazakos



A word from the expert:

Bee Garrs| Partner at Allabout Resumes| Career Coach| Resume Writer| Johannesburg, South Africa
Experience: 15 years

During the interview, you need to build rapport with the interviewer as quickly as possible. The successful candidate is always the one who not only has the skills, experience, and knowledge to do the job but the one whom the hiring manager feels is most similar to them.

An easy and quick method to build rapport is to match the speech of the hiring manager in terms of pace and timbre. To do this you need to be aware of your natural pace of speech and then observe whether the hiring manager speaks more quickly or more slowly than you do and whether they are loud, soft, high-pitched or low-pitched. Without imitating them, you need to match your natural speech to theirs by speaking more quickly or slowly, a little more loudly or softly etc.

By doing this, you subtly give the impression that you are similar to the hiring manager and they are more likely to enjoy the interaction with you.

Bee Garrs



A word from the expert:

Apeksha Ahluwalia| Manager, Human Resources| Johnson & Johnson| Mumbai, India
Experience: 5 years

- Have a confident handshake.
- Maintain direct eye contact with the interviewer. If you have a group interview, ensure that you are allocating time to address everyone on the panel.
- Ensure your answers are precise and to the point.
- Have some questions ready for the interviewer (s) including questions about:
 1. The organization & business strategy
 2. Alignment of your role to the business strategy
 3. Career growth trajectory

Apeksha Ahluwalia



A word from the expert:

**Karen McConnell Jones |CEO & President of Class Act
Productions LLC| Maryland-USA
Experience: 20 years**

I have interviewed people over the last 20 years. I know that some people are interview savvy; therefore, I will ask questions to learn a little more about how they handle adversity and challenges. I will also ask about the way they utilize their talents outside of work. I am interested in their community service and volunteerism.

Be prepared to talk about your short and long-term goals and examples of challenges you have faced. Tell me how you have worked through the challenges as well. I am looking for candidates that demonstrate balance.

Karen McConnell-Jones



A word from the expert:

Mark Anthony Dyson| Career Writer, Career Coach and Resume Writer| Founder of The Voice of Job Seekers| Chicago-USA
Experience: 12 years

If you, the job candidate, are ever unsure if you answered the question given or wondered how it comes across, you need to look for an opportunity to restate your answer. You must be savvy in your approach to your re-approach.

The best time for you to re-approach is during the part of the interview where you get an opportunity to ask the interviewer questions. Before you ask those questions, this is the best time to clarify anything that you feel may not have connected with the interviewer or fully answered an earlier question. You must succinctly and directly answer the question without lacking confidence or surety.

Be tactful and respectful by saying, "Before I ask some questions that I had, I want to be sure I answered all of your earlier questions fully. I am not sure if I answered your third question adequately. Do you mind if I take a moment to do so?"

It is not only respectful, but also welcomed, even if you have answered the question before.

Mark Anthony Dyson



A word from the expert:

Apeksha Ahluwalia| Manager, Human Resources| Johnson & Johnson| Mumbai, India

Experience: 5 years

- Walk-in as if you already have the job.
- Be confident but not over-confident.
- Prepare “**Your Story**” as the conversation starter.

Apeksha Ahluwalia



A word from the expert:

Alisa Quick, PHR, MPA| Director Human Resources & Public Relations| Housing Authority of the City of Winston-Salem| North Carolina, USA
Experience: 15 years

1. Be a part of the solution.

All businesses and organizations have their own problems and challenges. Some challenges are industry related hurdles (externally driven) while the others are internally fueled. Understand the difference between and significance of the two.

The most common challenges tend to be related to managing special projects and working effectively as a team or independently. Display your versatility and value as a candidate by providing specific scenarios where you rallied your teammates together to save the day. Even if you accidentally caused the hurdle to occur, make sure you took responsibility for your actions and resolved the matter in a timely fashion. Please remember to only include the true success stories (the negative ones can backfire in the interview).

2. Avoid speaking negatively about your previous or current employer.

It is obvious that you are looking for a new career opportunity for some reason or reasons. Make sure you show your most recent employer respect during all communication with your new potential employer (phone calls, small talk, presentations and, of course, the interview). This shows you are able to remain professional at all times, even if you may truly be disgruntled or frustrated with your most recent employer. It may also calm any of the interviewer(s)' suspicions about you being a "trouble maker" or "deserter" on the job. You are simply looking for a new opportunity to grow and develop your career as a professional.

3. Use a little humor to break the ice.

Do this in the beginning, somewhat during and definitely at the end of your interview process (but avoid overdoing it to the point that you do not appear serious about the job you are interviewing for). This is especially useful during a panel interview. If you find a positive way to connect with the leaders in the room, they will remember you when it comes to making a final selection of a top candidate. If you can make them smile and ease the tension in the room a bit, you appear to have a better chance of fitting in with the business culture. It may also help to calm your own nerves!

4. Remember to make a good first impression with the company as a whole.

This includes the security guard, the receptionist and any other staff you may pass by on your way to the interview (from the parking lot to the Boardroom). Make friendly eye contact and give a smile although you may be a bit nervous (never let them see you sweat). Whenever possible, research the location of the interview as well as any staff that may be on your interview panel (especially the one that will serve as your immediate supervisor).

5. Master the art of listening. Do your best to remember people's names, or at least their first names. If you are not very good at remembering names, make sure you remember at least one significant thing about each person you come in contact with that day.

Send yourself a short text (not in the interview) or discretely jot down a few notes about each one (especially any of the ones that interview you).

These bits of information may be very valuable as you try to connect with the team if you are selected for the job later. It will show you truly have an interest in who they are and what they do, without being nosy or inappropriate. For example, whose child plays softball or is on a dance team? What is their favorite reality show, or at least one they are talking about often? What is another person's favorite sports team? Who went to school in the same state as you did?

The truth is, most people enjoy sharing some of their personal interests with others. Let 'em talk while you take it all in. It will teach you about their personalities and give you a better idea of how to approach your work relationship while keeping an open line of communication with them in the future. Are they competitive, laid back, family-centered, an animal lover, slightly insecure or all of the above?

Alisa Quick

Chapter IV

Post Interview: Yep, it is still show time!



Ending the interview

At the end of the interview, the interviewer will ask if you have questions for them. Your answer should always be YES.

Have a list or memorize intelligent questions that are not self-serving. I understand that during the interview some of your questions may be answered. Try to have a go-to question or two in that case. My “go-to” question is “What are the next steps in the process?” OR “Is there anything else about my background, education or experience that I can clarify for you?” Some additional questions you can ask include:

- Are there upcoming projects and initiatives I will assist with if hired?
- What is the most challenging thing about this role?
- What skills and characteristics will an ideal candidate for this role have?
- How is success measured for the role? What does “doing a great job” look like?
- What area does the team I will be working for excel in?
- What types of challenges does the team I will be working with face?
- What is your management style?
- How can you describe the training process for the role? How long will training last?
- How would you describe the company’s culture and subculture of the department?

Self-serving questions:

Do not ask these questions. You will find out soon enough. These are great questions for the future or the offer stage.

- How does the company handle being off for doctors’ appointments?
- When will I be able to take time off if I am sick or for vacation?
- Is there a discount for products and services for employees?
- When will I be able to move to another department or be promoted?
- How much and/or when will I be paid?
- Is the manager a micro-manager or mean?

- Did I get the job?
- Are you interviewing many people for the job?

When the interview is over, be sure to thank everyone for his or her time. At this point, it is also critical to ask for the job IF you really want the job. If you are on the fence about it, ask for it anyway. You will have time to sort things out later.

By asking for the job, I do not mean that you should say, “Hey, I want this job.” You can say things like; “I am interested in this opportunity,” “I would be excited to join the team.” “After speaking to you, I am even more excited about the position and company.” Extend the invitation to them to contact you if they have any questions or need clarification on anything.

Be sure to ask for business cards or contact information from the interviewers. Trying to get this information after the fact may be difficult. You will need to prepare a follow-up thank you note for the interviewers.

Send a thank you note even if you do not want the job. There may be other opportunities in the organization you may be interested in later. It is important that you do not burn bridges, but rather make a great impression regardless of the outcome.

The thank you letter serves as another opportunity to reiterate your interest in the job.

Exiting the interview

Leave the interview the same way you came. Be polite to everyone you encounter while leaving. Refrain from smoking, talking on the cell phone and turning up your music until you are completely away from the campus. You are still being evaluated along the way.

Just when you thought you could relax, show time is not over. You may have guessed that, from the beginning to end of the process, you need to be prepared and stay on your toes throughout the entire process.



A word from the expert:

Apeksha Ahluwalia| Manager, Human Resources| Johnson & Johnson| Mumbai, India
Experience: 5 years

- Thank the interviewer(s) and give them a strong handshake.
- Make certain the interviewer/recruiter has information for your references: This is a tricky one as some organizations initiate reference checking while you are still serving your notice period. Hence, ensure that you share the right contacts with which you have a high level of trust and camaraderie.

These references should be from different facets of your work profile and at least one from each organization where you have worked.

- Analyze yourself – It is good to observe and note what was exceptional and what you can improve upon.

Apeksha Ahluwalia



A word from the expert:

**Devay Campbell: Author The BEST job Interview Advice Book|
Career Coach| Recruiter |North Carolina-USA
Experience 10 years**

Contrary to what you may believe, following up every day may not improve your chances of getting a job. There is a fine line between being passionate and eager or bothersome. The last thing you want to do is to appear too desperate or to be thought of as a pest.

If the recruiter or manager tells you that, they will make a decision in a week or two, following up after that time has passed is acceptable. After the thank you letter, one follow-up occurrence is sufficient. If they want you, they know how to find you.

Devay Campbell



A word from the expert:

**Karen McConnell Jones |CEO & President of Class Act
Productions LLC| Maryland-USA
Experience: 20 years**

Always follow up with a thank-you letter. I know that email is a new way;
however, I believe a hand written thank you note is more authentic.

Karen McConnell-Jones



A word from the expert:

**Ami Pendergrass| Career Coach| Job Seekers United| Leiden,
Netherlands**

Experience: 13 years

One of the questions I am commonly asked is, "Should I follow up?" We put a lot of hard work and effort into getting in the door, but as soon as the interview is over, many of us find ourselves unsure of whether it is okay to follow up with an employer.

The short answer to that question is emphatically yes! Interviewing is like sales.

You have presented your product, yourself, and as any good sales person would tell you, follow up is key to ensuring that you "close the deal".

Following up is expected and shows that you are keen on the position, which may even help push you ahead of another candidate that is being considered. If you get bad news, that is okay, too.

Your time is valuable and if they reject you, that is just more time in your pocket to move forward to the next potential opportunity.

Ami Pendergrass



A word from the Expert: LinkedIn Article on March 5, 2015

**Devay Campbell: Author The BEST Job Interview Advice Book|
Career Coach| Recruiter |North Carolina-USA
Experience 10 years**

Are you gambling with the post interview thank you letter? STOP NOW!

The post interview thank you letter seems like a small piece of the process, but it is actually bigger than you think. I have always valued the post interview thank you letter; however, one incident really helped me to understand the true value it adds.

A few years ago, I was working with a manager to find her an assistant manager. The manager was torn between the candidates but was really on the fence about one of them. I thought the candidate was a good choice, but it was not up to me. The Manager thought she was a little too reserved and not assertive enough for the clients she would interface with daily.

Then something happened to change the Manager's mind.

The not so assertive candidate sent me a thank you email. I forwarded it right away! The letter was well written and more importantly, the candidate asked for the job!

After reading the email, the Manager asked me one simple question: Did the other candidates send me a letter? I double checked my email and the stack of incoming mail on my desk. I finally replied “no.” The Manager promptly told me to offer the candidate the job. I was stunned! Needless to say, I made the offer and the candidate accepted the job.

Now, I cannot guarantee the letter will get you a job. What if the choice between you and another candidate was a close one? Would you want one more chance to confirm you are the best candidate and/or erase any doubt that you are interested in the job? I am sure you would.

Send a thank you note or email **each time**. No exceptions! I will also offer you the following advice.

- Send the note as soon as reasonably possible after the interview. A handwritten note or card still has the personable touch that goes a long way. Sending an email may be best if there is a time crunch. An email is certainly better than nothing at all.

I know that from the candidate’s view the process seems like it takes a long time. At times, it goes by fast. There are behind the scene things that make it seem longer, but candidate elimination does not take long. More often than not, the first round eliminations are made the same or next day.

Tip: If you want an electronic note card that has a traditional flare to it, (the best of both worlds) visit www.paperlesspost.com. Here you can create your own message and personalize the card. Paperlesspost.com will give you a certain number of credits (the currency for purchasing products) at no cost. You can always purchase more for a nominal fee.

Be careful not to select anything too playful or whimsical. They are cute cards but keep in mind this is business not personal. You will need an email address to send the card.

- Send the thank you letter after each interview in the process (including a phone interview-which can be emailed).

- Ask for a business card of the interviewer(s). If you do not get their email address or contact information, it could be hard to track them down later. The receptionist or gatekeepers will protect this information at times. If all else fails, ask the recruiter to forward the information on your behalf. This is what I did in the scenario above.
- Make sure the letter reiterates your skills and qualifications as they relate to things discussed in the interview. Yes, you have to listen, ask questions and maybe take notes.

Example:

“I welcome the challenge of assisting the Marketing team with developing a new branding campaign in June 2015. I share your belief that reaching Millennials is paramount to the continued success of ABC organization. I developed an identical campaign for XYZ organization that resulted in 36% growth with the target audience.”

- **Ask for the job** and/or to move to the next step in the process

Stack the odds in your favor. Do not gamble with this important part of the selection process.

Devay Campbell

Chapter V

The Job Offer



You should be proud of yourself even if you do not receive a job offer. Interviewing is never an easy process. You have to be transparent in front of strangers and convince them that you are worthy of a chance to work alongside them.

In this chapter, we will provide you with some guidance on what to do in both scenarios (offer or not).

You received an offer but you are not interested.

Remember at the beginning of the book, I said that you do not have to accept ANY interview? The same is true about a job. You really do not have to accept

a job. Going through the interview process may reveal things about that job that you are not able or willing to accept. Here are a few reasons not to accept the job:

1. The pay will create hardship for your family. There are times where accepting less pay will not be a hardship and/or other compensation or things about the job will make up for the shortage. For instance, if you will save time, gas or benefits, do not allow the pay be the deciding factor. Any improvement in the quality of your life is priceless.
2. The people interviewing you (especially your immediate supervisor) displayed characteristics that will make you uncomfortable working with them.
3. The job you applied to is different from the job explained during the interview. If the change is significant enough that it ends up being a job you cannot do or are not willing to do – move on. Leave yourself open for future opportunities that may arise.
4. The expectations of the job, including schedule, travel, and other non-negotiable factors are misaligned with your lifestyle and needs.



A word from the expert:

Bee Garrs| Partner at Allabout Resumes| Career Coach| Resume Writer| Johannesburg, South Africa
Experience: 15 years

Turning down a job offer gracefully is important because it tells the hiring manager a lot about your personal character. You don't want your last impression to be a negative one. You never know when you might encounter the same hiring manager in the future, whether in another company or at a conference.

When turning down a job offer, remember to be respectful. Always thank the hiring manager for considering you as a candidate and be honest about the specific reason for not accepting the offer.

It is fine to say that you enjoyed getting to know the company and the team but that you received another offer that is more in line with the future career path you would like to pursue. However, it is not ok to say that you do not like the style of the hiring manager or that the salary they offered was too low. Learning to turn down a job offer gracefully today will leave you in a good position for future job opportunities.

Bee Garrs

You didn't get the job:

Not getting the job is not the expected outcome unless it was clear in the interview that there was a mismatch. Most people walk away feeling great about the interview. If you do not receive an offer, it will be ok. There will be other opportunities.

If you do not get the job, this is not the chance to be disgruntled and unprofessional. You should actually be quite the opposite. After all, it is how you handle disappointments that will reveal the most about your character. Do not demand answers as to why you were not selected, threaten to sue, take the matter to someone higher up the chain of command, or be rude to the person contacting you. Being a sore loser will make things worse.



A word from the expert:

Bee Garrs| Partner at Allabout Resumes| Career Coach| Resume Writer| Johannesburg, South Africa
Experience: 15 years

What should you do if you don't get the job?

It always feels disappointing not to be the successful candidate; however, a common and unfortunate mistake that candidates often make is viewing this as the end of the process.

Even if you are not successful, you should write a letter or an email to the hiring manager to thank them for considering you for the role. It is a good opportunity to reiterate that the interview confirmed all the things that interested you about the company, e.g. that they have a participative culture or that the company values are very much aligned with your own.

By doing this, you leave the hiring manager feeling that they have had a positive interaction with you and you are much more likely to be considered as a shortlist candidate for future job opportunities with the company. Before starting the recruitment process, recruiters, headhunters, and hiring managers are always likely to think about the people that they know who might be a

good candidate for the job, so make sure that the impression you give them is a positive and long-lasting one.

Bee Garrs

You received the offer, but you are not totally satisfied with the salary.

Negotiating your job offer is extremely important. You will not have another chance at this once you accept the offer and you are hired.

Be sure to write down everything that is offered to you. If you are not in a position to give the conversation your undivided attention, ask if you can call back when you when you can give the conversation your undivided attention.

One of the best things to do before you are in a position to discuss salary and benefits is to research what is standard in the industry. Some helpful places to evaluate pay will include Glassdoor.com, Payscale.com, and Salary.com. You should not rely on this research alone. Research similar companies to see if they list their salaries on job posting. Benefits information can sometimes be found on the company's website too.

Entering a conversation about salary and benefits without being prepared will set you up for failure. Most companies will offer a fair wage based on the market and what their budgets can withstand, but do not rely on them to do the work for you. Even if you have no plans of challenging the offer, you should be aware of your value.

During the offer phase, do not belittle the offer, talk bad about the company or allow any amount of arrogance to peak its head during the conversation. The company is aware that you are thebomb.com that is why they are giving you an offer. If their offer is not up to par in your eyes, do not take it as a personal attack. This is your chance to ask for what you want and give brief explanations of why.

Be clear about your expectations and always thank them for their offer. I would always take a day or two to review the information and come back with a counter offer if necessary.

If you are ready to negotiate at the time the offer is presented, go ahead. I will guarantee that between the excitement and heap of information you will be

receiving, you will have some questions. Remember, you will not have time to go back and forth after you have said yes to the offer.

Ways to start the offer conversation:

Option 1

I am so excited you are extending this offer to me. I am excited about the possibility of joining the team. I would like to think about the offer and get back to you by _____ (fill in the blank). Thank you.

Option 2

I am so excited you are extending this offer to me. I am excited about the possibility of joining the team.

I would like to discuss the offer and if we can get a little closer aligned. My salary expectation is _____. This is a fair offer based on my qualifications and skills and _____ years of experience. I would like you to consider these things.

After the offer is presented to you a second time, the company may be firm on the offer.

If you are still not satisfied, think of other ways to offset the pay if you can afford to. You may be able to negotiate a salary review sooner than the norm. Perhaps you would normally be evaluated for a raise annually; maybe you can negotiate a raise in six months instead.

The company may consider a sign on bonus. This is usually reserved for hard to fill, niche, or upper-level positions. Anyone can ask for it. All they can do is say no.

A bigger 401K match or deferred comp investment from the company may be another option. The pay is not immediate, but it is still compensation just the same.

Vacation and time off is an area that I have had the most requests for increasing during the offer stage. Since time off is paid at your normal pay rate it gives you the best of both worlds.

One note about time off: check the company policy. Some companies do not track time vacation and sick time. Negotiating time off would be futile in this case.

A tuition reimbursement increase over the standard policy can reduce out of pocket expenses if you are currently in school or planning to enroll.

A telecommuting (ability to work from home) option will save you time and money. Receiving approval to work from home a fixed number of times per month will result in savings.

The individual and the company more than likely share insurance premiums and other benefits. If the company agrees to pay more of the cost, your portion will be less.

Warning: Don't over negotiate

I really believe you should ask for any and everything you want at this stage.

Be careful not to over negotiate and appear too greedy. It is important to remember that submitting a counter-offer is viewed the same as declining the presented offer. If you make matters too complicated and lengthy, the company will offer the position to the runner up. In the past, I have had to end negotiations and go to the next candidate. I was disappointed because I really wanted the number one candidate on the team; however, it is not personal it is business.

At some point, you have to realize that you are too far apart to agree.

In business, there are budgetary guidelines and hiring deadlines. At that point, both the business and the candidate will need to decide when they are just too far apart to agree and move on.

Try to see things from the company's point of view. Look at the overall picture. I am sure there are things on your list that are "must haves" and some are "nice to have" items. Know the difference. Be concise, fair, and clear in your expectations. Make a decision within a timely manner.



A word from the expert:

Apeksha Ahluwalia| Manager, Human Resources| Johnson & Johnson| Mumbai, India
Experience: 5 years

Evaluate the complete offer package: Keep in mind that your job is a consolidation of multiple aspects: brand of the organization, your role, responsibilities, compensation, scope and impact of role, designation and people managerial responsibility. Prioritize which aspects are critical for you and which aspects are not as important. In short, identifying what you are prepared to “Give Up” is as necessary as what you really “Want” in the opportunity.

Negotiating: Ensure that you are assertive while negotiating the offer. Make sure you have your expectations communicated clearly to the hiring managers and others involved.

Apeksha Ahluwalia

The counter offer from your current organization

A staffing agency manager provided me with statistics that said 91% of employees that take a counter offer from their current employers would be looking to leave the company again within six months. I am not sure how true that is, but it is something to consider. If your motivation to leave was purely financial, the counter offer may solve your problem. Of course, there will be the feeling of “If they could do this to get me to stay, they could have done this all along” to keep me happy.

If the reason for leaving was something other than money, I am not sure if things would change because you decided to leave. My best advice is to evaluate the situation fully. Give it some time and sleep on it. Consult your personal Board of Directors but the final choice is yours. Decide what you can live with long term.



A word from the expert:

Bee Garrs| Partner at Allabout Resumes| Career Coach| Resume Writer| Johannesburg, South Africa
Experience: 15 years

How to handle the counter offer

One of the trickiest situations candidates can find themselves in is the situation where they hand in their resignation letter and the manager proceeds to offer more money, more flexibility and even a better job title. It may be tempting to accept the offer, but you should consider a few things before blindly accepting.

First, think and write down all the reasons you started looking for another job and then think whether all the things you found frustrating about your present role or company will vanish because you are being paid more or have a longer job title.

By accepting the counter offer, your employer will always remember that you were ready to leave the company but were easily persuaded and this will leave them wondering about your integrity and loyalty which could jeopardize your future long-term success at the company.

Bee Garrs

Whether you are leaving another job or not may make a difference to when you will be able to start with the new employee. Of course, you will want to give at least a two-week notice with your current employer. Some positions require as much as a thirty-day notice.

If you are transferring to another role within the company, make sure you understand the rules of your organization for transfers.

Deciding between two offers

It is my wish for you that you have the opportunity to have more than one offer. At times, the decision is clear. If you are anything like me, you want some real reassurance that you are making the right decision. First, there are no guarantees. I will offer you a way to arrive at an answer when there is not an obvious front-runner. You can also use this method to decide between an offer and your current job. I have done this a few times and it is the closest thing to logic in my eyes.

First, write down your pros and cons for each position you are evaluating.

Some things on your list should include:

Pay, Benefits, Culture, Travel, Team/Supervisor, Assignments, Advancement, Location, Company's mission in relation to your beliefs, Company investment in your growth etc... There may be other things specifically related to what will make you happy.

Create a pros and cons list for the companies you are considering and categorize characteristics of the job. Assign a number to each item from one to five. One is the lowest and five is the highest score possible.

Keep in mind when you are working on the cons list, a five means you are unhappy with that item.

Then, add both lists and subtract the cons from the pros for each job.
Whichever job has the highest number of points at the end wins!

Example 3

Job 1 Pros

Home every night-no travel-(5)

Pay-(4)

Boss' values aligned with my values-(3)

Location-5 minutes from my home-(5)

Total 17

Cons

Benefits- no 401k-(4)

Culture is ok not great-(3)

Total 7 points

Pros 17 minus Cons 7=10

Job 2 Pros

Benefits-(5)

Pay-(4)

Culture-(5)

Work Assignments-(5)

Total-19

Cons

Travel up to 50 %-(5)

Location: 45-minute commute-(5)

Total-10

Pros 19 minus Cons 10=9

In this example, it looks like job number 1 won is by one point. If the difference is only one point, I would look at my highest rated con for each job

and make a choice.

In this case, the long commute and travel of job #2 and the lack of the 401k in job #1 rate the highest. I would have to ask myself is it more important that my job is 5 minutes away vs. 45 minutes or that I have a 401K? Is it important to me to be home every night versus traveling?

Of course, if the difference is a long shot, your answer will be more obvious. Either way, relax. Having two offers is a great problem to have!

Writing things down really helps. The key is being honest with yourself about what is most important to you and only you. Also, follow your gut. Sometimes, the choice is not mathematic at all.

Ten interview bloopers and the lessons you can learn from them

I had a candidate show up in the lobby, well dressed and prompt for his TELEPHONE interview.

Lesson: Listen and write down instructions. Do not let the excitement of getting the interview keep you from missing important details.

I asked a candidate about her weakness. She replied that she had a weakness for elderly people and went into a long story about the elderly that even involved tears.

Lesson: Keep your answers business related. Practice emotional intelligence.

A co-worker had a candidate show up and explain that he broke his button on his pants. He proceeded to lift his shirt and exposed the fact that his pants were coming down (and his underwear) to the hiring manager.

Lesson: Be professional and appropriate regardless of the situation.

One of my candidates mentioned that he was a body model in between jobs. He did say that he was not “always” nude.

Lesson: See number 2 and 3

A candidate decided the interview was over after I asked two questions. The last question was, “What is the most you have ever done to ensure that a customer received great customer service?”

Lesson: The interviewee was professional and graceful when she exited the interview. Her timing? Not so much.

I interviewed a candidate that would talk about unrelated stories versus answering the question I asked him. I learned a lot about his family and

military career and nothing about his qualifications for the job. At one time, I thought he took my redirecting the interview as a green light to bring up another unrelated story!

Lesson: Be brief but answer the questions fully. Stay on course. Refrain from too many personal, unrelated comments and examples.

An interviewee called me back to ask if I can get a phone number of a co-worker that was in the elevator with us before his interview. When I refused, he asked if I could give her his phone number instead.

Lesson: Make sure you are professional after the interview as well. Interviewing is not the time to find a date or anything else that may be inappropriate. You can blow it at any point in the process.

An internal candidate came to the interview eating candy. After enduring a few minutes of her chewing and talking, I said, “Are you really going to eat candy?” She said “yes,” opened her purse pulled out the pack and offered me a piece.

Lesson: If you are interviewing within your company and familiar with the interviewer(s), be as professional as you would interviewing at an external company with strangers.

One candidate emailed me a well-written thank-you letter after the interview. The problem was that the letter was intended for another company.

Lesson: Double check all correspondences, including making sure you send them to the right company and person. Do not let interviewing with multiple companies get you off track.

I will pick on myself for this example. Years ago, I had landed an interview with a company I was very interested in working for. I aced the interview and was invited back to take an assessment. The assessment had an audio component to. About 10 other candidates sat in a room with tape recorders and headsets. We had to listen to the audio before answering some questions.

I sat at the desk looking at everyone else start the assessment while I waited for mine to begin. By the time I realized that the volume was turned completely down, I had missed more than half of the recording. I tried to answer the questions with limited information. I knew the outcome would not be pleasant.

I was so disappointed. I am sure I failed the exam and that was why I did not get that job. I interviewed (and received an offer) from the same company in a different role many years later. I was so nervous just walking into the building. I ended up turned the offer down and accepting another opportunity but felt like I had redeemed myself.

Lesson: Pay attention to detail, prepare and ask questions. Get the instructions ahead of time, and follow them! In addition, even when you know you are drowning, keep going. You never know what position you would be in later.



One last word from the expert: Be encouraged on your career journey!

Article posted on LinkedIn, February 2, 2015

By: Devay Campbell

Don't miss the career advice provided by the Patriot's Super Bowl win.

I have given career advice to many people throughout my career and lifetime. I will leverage all my personal and professional experience to guide and coach those seeking my help. I am always amazed that some of the best lessons come from unexpected places.

I will admit that I am not a diehard sports fan; however, I enjoy the competition and energy of a good game. This Super Bowl did not disappoint! It offered all that could have been expected by sports fanatics and so much more! This Super Bowl had lessons for anyone that has been let go or denied employment and the "under the radar" unassuming employee waiting on their moment to shine.

Let me explain.

The Carolina Panthers released Brandon Lafelle in the summer of 2014 after they decided not to renew his contract. I am sure, just like most of us with career disappointments; Lafelle was confused, angry and hurt, to say the least. He moved on and it was a great thing.

Lesson 1: The Carolina Panthers actually did him a favor. If he was still with the Panthers, he would have missed the opportunity to play in or **WIN** the Super Bowl. The lesson is obvious here. Even though it is a hard pill to swallow, sometimes there is something better for you on the other side of a downsizing, restructuring, termination or job offer you did not get but desperately wanted. Get past the hurt and prepare for the next big thing. Yes, prepare!

Lesson 2: Malcolm Butler was an unsigned, free agent from West Alabama. That was his status until that night (after the Super Bowl). He has a new identity now. He will be forever known as the guy that caught the interception that put the Patriots in the Super Bowl winner's seat! I am sure he was nervous and anxious. At that moment, he knew what he had to do and he did it. Win, lose or draw, he had to take a chance. No pressure, right?

Keep in mind that Butler had to catch the ball. Simply blocking the pass would not have been good enough. The Seahawks would have still had the ball (and another chance to win) with a block. Butler had to go all in! He did it, it worked and they won. The end.

All you need is ONE moment to shine, the proper preparation, and a team that trusts you to get the job done. More importantly, you have to trust yourself. You may not think you are the most qualified or that there are others on your team that may deserve it more. Do not cheat yourself out the chance to be extraordinary. The ball is in your court. Volunteer for the assignment, step up, lead or share your idea. Whatever it is...just do it!

Full disclosure: I am a Carolina Panther's fan and I really wanted the Seahawks to win that night. Either way, I enjoyed the lessons from the game. That brings me to

Lesson 3: It may be hard, but try to look for the silver lining in every cloud. Don't spend too much time on the negative things. That is a career killer for sure.

Devay Campbell

Conclusion

Thank you for taking the time to read **The BEST Job Interview Advice Book**. If you read the book from cover to the conclusion, you should have noticed that every part of the interview involves being prepared. Being prepared is mentioned in this book over a few dozen times. I have given you a few examples in the book and some additional pages to note your thoughts. This is the beginning process to getting prepared.

Confidence is the other factor that leads to successful interviewing. Although confidence is something that comes from within, some external factors can build or tear down one's confidence too. I understand that.

Reading **The BEST Job Interviewing Advice Book** is a start to gaining self-awareness and building the confidence needed to walk through the interview doors and present your best self. Being prepared will ultimately make you more confident. The rest of these things take practice. Practice makes perfect. Interviewing will become easier for you in time.

The contributors and I have not held back on any advice provided in this book.

We want you to land the job of your dreams. I will be waiting to hear all about it!

Email me devaycampbell@career2cents.com

Happy Interviewing!

Receive FREE career tips right to your mailbox!

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